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CALMING CURRENTS

Nepal votes today in first post-protest election

WORLD PAGE



STATUE NARRATIVES

Lutyens and the politics of symbolism

The attempts to avenge the past and rewrite the future

OPINION » PAGE 5



CALL FOR ACTION

India ranks second in children with obesity

NEWS » PAGE 8



PACKING A PUNCH

Black Caps stun the Proteas, enter final

SPORT » PAGE 9

U.S. sinks Iranian vessel near Sri Lanka

Sri Lankan Navy responds to distress call, rescues 32 sailors and recovers 83 bodies

U.S. submarine used torpedo to sink Iran's ship in international waters, says Hegseth

Ship was returning from Visakhapatnam after global maritime exercise in February

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

U.S. submarine attacked an Iranian warship on Wednesday, which sank in the Indian Ocean off the coast of Sri Lanka, bringing the West Asian conflict closer to the Indian subcontinent. At least 83 people were killed in the torpedo attack.

U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth confirmed the strike at a press conference in Washington DC. "An American submarine sunk an Iranian warship that thought it was safe in international waters. Instead, it was sunk by a torpedo," Mr. Hegseth said, terming it a "quiet death" and the "first sinking of an enemy ship" by a torpedo since the Second World War. "Like in that war," Mr. Hegseth said, "we are fighting to win".

The Sri Lankan Navy rescued 32 sailors and recovered 83 bodies after a dawn distress call from the Iranian frigate *IRIS Dena*, which sank about 40 naut-

U.S. and Israel hammer Iran on fifth day of war

DUBAI

The U.S. and Israel hit Iran's capital and other cities in air strikes on Wednesday, the fifth day of the war with Iran, as the Islamic Republic responded with missile barrages and drone attacks across the region. The Israeli military said air defences were activated to intercept Iranian missiles fired at targets around the country, and explosions were heard around Jerusalem. » WORLD

Out in the ocean

The Iranian ship that sunk off Sri Lankan coast on Wednesday was returning from the International Fleet Review 2026 held in Visakhapatnam in February

IRIS Dena, one of 6 Moudge Class Frigates of Iran, was commissioned in June 2021

IRIS Dena had a crew capacity of nearly 180 with around 140 persons believed to be on board

Sri Lanka Navy rescued 32 sailors and recovered 83 bodies

The U.S. has not sunk enemy ships by torpedo since the Second World War



SRI LANKA

Galle

The warship sank around 40 nautical miles off Galle on Sri Lanka's southern coast



Sunken ship: IRIS Dena in the Bay of Bengal on February 18. AFP

Indices tumble as markets respond to oil uncertainty

MUMBAI

Indian investors continued selling on Wednesday, triggering the benchmark indices to tumble in the second consecutive session as oil prices surged on closure of Strait of Hormuz. The benchmark Nifty 50 and Sensex 30 closed at 24,480.50 and 79,116.19 points, down 1.5% and 1.4% respectively on Wednesday, responding to the oil shock. » BUSINESS

Nitish may enter RS, make way for new BJP CM

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

While Bihar celebrated Holi, Patna witnessed hectic political activity on Wednesday over reports that Janata Dal(U) leader Nitish Kumar would resign as Chief Minister and go to the Rajya Sabha.

Top BJP sources told *The Hindu* that Bihar would soon have a new Chief Minister.

"At a meeting of their party with JD(U) leaders held after the results of Assembly election in Bihar, a suggestion was made that a succession plan for the government be made within

New roles: While the JD(U) chief could file RS nomination on Thursday, his son Nishant Kumar is set to join the party. ANI

a year of the results. It was conveyed that a succession plan for the government needed to be in place factoring in the future of the

JD(U)," a source said.

If Mr. Kumar relinquishes his post, the next Chief Minister would be from the BJP. Party sources said "he/

she will be from the backward class".

JD(U) leader Zama Khan said that Mr. Kumar's son Nishant Kumar would join the party on Thursday. "Yes, Nishant Kumar is going to join the party tomorrow at 11 a.m. and it will strengthen both our party and its organisation," the State's Minister of Minority Welfare told presspersons.

Sources said that Union Home Minister Amit Shah will visit Patna on Thursday to be present on the occasion of possible "regime change" in the State on a day when NDA's Rajya Sabha candidates, including BJP president Nitin Na-

bin, will file their nominations.

Earlier, coming out of a meeting at the Chief Minister's official residence, JD (U) MLC and long-time close aide to Mr. Kumar, Sanjay Gandhi, said, "We'll support whatever decision Nitish Kumar will take. We'll support him even if he goes to the Rajya Sabha."

Party sources said Mr. Kumar may file his nomination for the Rajya Sabha on Thursday morning.

CONTINUED ON

» PAGE 6

MVA BACKS SHARAD FOR RS

» PAGE 7

Hindi words removed from arch at Tiruchi Railway Division office

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUCHI

Authorities of the Tiruchi Railway Division removed the words '*Kartavya Dwar*' (Gateway of Duty) from the newly built entrance arch at the office of the Divisional Railway Manager on Wednesday evening.

The move followed a political row over the use of the Hindi term.

The words in Hindi, Tamil, and English were fully removed from the arch built in front of the office situated close to the main entrance to the Tiruchi Railway Junction. Divisional railway officials said the words were removed from the arch "respecting the sentiments" of the people.

Prior to this, a group of

Contentious issue: A worker removing the words from the archway of the railway office in Tiruchi on Wednesday. M. MOORTHY

DMK cadre and office-bearers, led by Tiruchi Mayor M. Anbazhagan, smeared black paint on the English words '*Kartavya Dwar*' on a stone tablet installed near the arch to mark its commissioning.

Earlier in the day, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K.

Stalin had taken strong objection to the practice of writing Hindi names even in Tamil and English, instead of using appropriate terms in the respective languages.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2

T.N. polls: DMK seals pact as Congress gets 28 seats, one Rajya Sabha berth

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

The ruling DMK and the Congress signed a seat-sharing pact for the election to the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly, after days of uncertainty and hard bargain. According to the agreement, signed by DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai, the Congress will contest 28 seats, three more than its 2021 election allotment. It has also been given a Rajya Sabha berth.

The alliance, which at one point appeared to collapse over demands for power-sharing and more seats, was saved after Congress veteran P. Chidambaram stepped in as an emis-

Dust settles: Tamil Nadu Congress president Selvaperunthagai after talks with DMK chief M.K. Stalin in Chennai on Wednesday. PTI

sary of the party high command and held discussions with Mr. Stalin on Tuesday.

Key meetings

Mr. Stalin reached Anna Arivalayam, the DMK headquarters, before the arrival of the Congress leaders on Wednesday night. Girish

Chodankar, AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu and head of the Congress seat-sharing committee, Mr. Selvaperunthagai, Congress Legislature Party leader Rajesh Kumar and others met the Chief Minister before the agreement was signed.

Mr. Selvaperunthagai said the TNCC and the Con-

gress high command would announce the candidate for the Rajya Sabha seat. "We are happy and have a sense of fulfilment," he said. Mr. Chodankar said formal talks on seat-sharing for Puducherry would begin on Thursday.

The agreement confirmed the continuation of 22 years of alliance which began in 2004, though there was a brief hiatus before the 2014 Lok Sabha polls. This time, the Congress began the talks on a discordant note demanding more seats and a power-sharing arrangement. As discussions hit a road-block, Mr. Chidambaram was asked to negotiate.

VALUES OVER STAR POWER

» PAGE 4

NEARBY

CMRL to roll out wheelchair ramps this month

CHENNAI

Wheelchair users commuting via the Chennai Metro Rail system will finally have access to a portable ramp, a long-pending demand, to comfortably board the train this month. » PAGE 2

Subdued heat to persist in parts of T.N. till Sunday

CHENNAI

Most parts of the State may be spared from the summer heat for a few days, as maximum temperatures are likely to hover around normal. The subdued heat pattern may continue till March 8 before a gradual rise in temperatures sets in. » PAGE 3

'Thiruneermalai tank set to be restored by April'

CHENNAI

About 50% of the restoration work on the temple tank at Thiruneermalai, which began on January 7, has been completed, according to temple authorities. who have said the renovation would be completed by April. » PAGE 3

METROPLUS » 4 PAGES

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Stalin inaugurates auditorium at college, distributes laptops

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday inaugurated the ‘Muthamizh Arignar Kalaignar’ Auditorium, built within Presidency College campus in Chennai at a cost of ₹63 crore, and distributed laptops to students under the *Ulagam Ungal Kaiyil* initiative. An official release said the Chief Minister had announced the construction of a hostel for persons with disabilities and an auditorium in the name of former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi, within the Presidency College premises, during the institution’s convocation in July 2022. The fully air-conditioned auditorium has been built over an area of 60,672 sq.ft.



National Safety Day celebrated at Renault Group’s plant in city

The 55th National Safety Day was celebrated at Renault Group’s Chennai plant, Renault Nissan Automotive India Private Limited (RNAIPL) on Wednesday. Director of Industrial Safety and Health S. Ananth, Additional Director C. Saravanan, and Joint Director S. Elangovan, took part in the celebrations. V.M. Keerthi Prakash, Managing Director, RNAIPL, delivered the keynote address.

Cong. leader Christopher Tilak frontrunner for RS seat

Congress party sources on Wednesday night said that the party would “most likely nominate a Christian candidate” to the Rajya Sabha from Tamil Nadu. With senior Congress leaders in Tamil Nadu such as Su. Thirunavukkarasar angled for the Rajya Sabha spot, multiple sources said M. Christopher Tilak, secretary of the All India Congress Committee (AICC), is the frontrunner.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 5, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- What sparked the DoD-Anthropic clash?
[newsth.live/anthropicclash](#)
- Chronic traffic noise exposes kinks in India’s urban regulations
[newsth.live/trafficnoise](#)

You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access these articles. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Tank of centuries-old temple in Thiruneermalai set to be restored by April, say officials

50% of work on the tank at Sri Ranganathaperumal Temple near Chromepet over; concrete laying work and removal of silt under way, compound wall to be built, CCTV cameras to be installed

WATER WATCH

T. Arvind
CHENNAI

About 50% of the restoration work on the temple tank at Thiruneermalai has been completed, according to temple authorities.

The work at the centuries-old *Manikarnika Theertham*, the tank of Sri Ranganathaperumal Temple, began on January 7, 2026.

Earlier, the authorities informed the Madras High Court that the renovation of the temple tank at Thiruneermalai near Chromepet would be completed by April.

A new concrete platform has been laid around the *Neerazhi Mandapam* at the centre of the tank. Concrete layers are being laid on steps and on the four corners of the tank.

Steps are being taken to prevent debris from entering the water and to curb soil erosion.

Work on desilting and removal of weeds is nearing completion. “While it was difficult for the excavators to reach the bottom of the tank initially, the accumulated silt and weeds have now been almost



A platform has been laid around the *Neerazhi Mandapam* at the centre of the temple tank. T. ARVIND

cleared,” said Jagan, who is engaged in the work.

Once the work inside the tank are completed, restoration of damaged architectural elements at the *Neerazhi Mandapam* will be taken up. Plans are also under way to construct a compound wall and install CCTV cameras and lighting around the tank.

Renovation of temple

Separately, a private donor, Ashokan, has undertaken the renovation of the hill temple.

A priest said original murals and inscriptions, which had become obscure over time, were be-

ing restored using a water-blast technique.

The issue drew attention after *The Hindu* reported on November 28, 2025, on the poor condition of the tank at the temple, which is attached to one of the 108 Vaishnavite Divya Desams.

At the time, the temple had said that an estimate of ₹63 lakh had been forwarded to the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department for rejuvenation works.

During the hearing in early February, it was submitted that Mr. Ashokan had undertaken to execute the entire project at an esti-

mated cost of ₹65 lakh.

Devotees have welcomed the restoration works, but stressed the need for sustained maintenance. “After restoration, proper upkeep is essential,” said Manivannan, a resident.

The temple, associated with the Vaishnavite saints Bhoothathazhwar and Thirumangai Alvar, contains inscriptions dating to the Chola, Pandya, and Vijayanagara periods.

Devotees expressed hope that the sanctity of the ancient shrine and its tank would be preserved through regular maintenance.

‘Drop move to redeploy posts for psychology faculty positions’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Government Doctors’ Association (TNGDA) has demanded that the Health Department drop its move to redeploy assistant and associate professor posts to create teaching faculty positions for psychology.

In a letter to the Health Secretary, the association welcomed the recent efforts to introduce undergraduate and postgraduate courses in Psychology in medical college hospitals. However, it stressed that these programmes must be

implemented in accordance with the National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions (NCAHP) norms.

The association noted that the courses were being started based on the guidelines of the Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI). It said the recommendations of the NCAHP should be adhered to, instead of following the RCI, which is not affiliated with the Health Department.

It also demanded that the required facilities be created to start the psychology courses.

The association had ear-

lier pointed out that several doctor posts in government medical college hospitals were recently redeployed to other institutions solely on the basis of National Medical Commission (NMC) norms.

Objecting to this, the TNGDA urged the Health Department not to proceed with such redeployments, solely based on NMC norms, without considering the patient load at the respective institutions.

Efforts are under way to redeploy associate professor and professor posts too, a move the association said was objectionable.

Nadaswaram exponent Sheik Mahaboob Subhani dies at 71

Nahla Nainar
TIRUCHI

Nadaswaram exponent Sheik Mahaboob Subhani passed away after a brief illness at Srirangam on Wednesday. He was 71 and is survived by his wife and three children.

He, along with his wife Kaleeshabi Mahboob, received the Padma Shri award in 2020.

Representing the eighth generation of a family of nadaswaram vidwans, Sheik Mahaboob was originally from Peda Kothapalli village in Prakasam District, Andhra Pradesh.



Sheik Mahaboob Subhani

He learned to play the nadaswaram from his grandfather and Andhra Pradesh State government awardee Janab Sheik Chinna Peer Sahib, and later his father, Sheik Meera Sahib, from the age of seven.

However, due to financial constraints, he became

an office worker in a tobacco factory.

His marriage to Kaleeshabi, his first cousin, led him back to the family’s musical legacy.

In an earlier interview with *The Hindu*, the maestro had said, “When we got married, my skill with the nadaswaram was almost nil, because I lacked practice. I asked Kaleeshabi for a year to relearn the instrument, enough at least to support her in concerts.”

Family sources said Sheik Mahaboob Subhani’s funeral would be held in Srirangam on Thursday.

THE HINDU

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Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	34	20
Chennai Airport	34	23
Chennai City	33	24

Chennai Airport Today
34°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be warm. Night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night will be pleasant.

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Timings
CHENNAI

THURSDAY, MAR. 05
RISE 06:23 SET 18:18
RISE 19:57 SET 07:25
FRIDAY, MAR. 06
RISE 06:22 SET 18:19
RISE 20:45 SET 08:01
SATURDAY, MAR. 07
RISE 06:22 SET 18:19
RISE 21:35 SET 08:39

Sowcarpet jewellery unit blast toll hits 5 as two workers die

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The death toll in the recent cylinder blast at a jewellery manufacturing unit in Sowcarpet has increased to five.

On February 25, a gas cylinder exploded in the jewellery-making shop owned by Sumanpal Bisojit, 35, on the fourth floor of a commercial building on Singannan Street of Sowcarpet.

Migrant workers

The owner of the unit and seven workers, hailing from West Bengal, were seriously injured.

They were rushed to the Rajiv Gandhi Government General Hospital immediately.

However, within a few hours, the owner died

Early on Wednesday, two more workers from West Bengal, Suraj and Aravind, died without responding to treatment

without responding to treatment.

The workers – S. Arvind Nangal, B. Simanthopal, J. Asim, Suraj, Jantho Indrajit, Rakesh Deli, and Anand – had been undergoing treatment.

However, Simanthopal and Rakesh died at the hospital the next day.

In the early hours of Wednesday, two more workers, Suraj and Aravind, who were undergoing treatment at the Government Kilpauk Medical College Hospital, died.

Assistant held for murdering owner of snack shop

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 50-year-old snack shop owner in Tiruvallur was killed by his kitchen assistant on Tuesday night.

Chinnappan was running a snack shop in Magaral of Tiruvallur district, and had employed Panchaanan Root, a native of Odisha, as his assistant in the kitchen.

On Tuesday night, Chinnappan spotted Panchaanan consuming liquor in the kitchen and warned him against it.

Subsequently, Panchaanan assaulted him with a heavy utensil, killing him on the spot.

On being alerted, the Vengal police sent the body to Government Tiruvallur hospital for a post-mortem and arrested the assistant.

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74	26261005	Running Contract for One Year for supply of HVN-66 insulating Liner as per RDSO Drawing No. T-8751	3650600 Nos	01-Apr-26
75	26267091	Running Contract for One Year for supply of HVN-66 insulating Liner as per RDSO Drawing No. T-3707 to 3708	150000 Set	30-Mar-26
76	09253165	OVERHAULING KIT	3380 Set	30-Mar-26
77	15252290	LATERAL DAMPER	1101 Nos	30-Mar-26
78	15262022	AXLE BOX PIVOT BUSH	4419 Nos	26-Mar-26
79	11265001	Design, fabrication, supply, erection, testing and commissioning of Hydraulic Buffers	4 Set	25-Mar-26
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Please read the due date as “13.03.2026” for the tender notice no S-06-2026 dated: 28.01.2026 at Sr. No. 53				
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1.	Construction of Semi Covered shed for Paddy Storage along with basic amenities of 1500 MT Capacity (1x1500M.T) in survey No.218 to an extent of 1,64,773 Sqft or 3.77 Acres at Peruncheri Village in Kuthalam Taluk in Mayiladuthurai District.	1,06,000.00
2.	Construction of Semi Covered shed for Paddy Storage along with basic amenities of 7000 MT Capacity (2x3000M.T & 1x1000M.T) in survey No.283/1 and 284/1 to an extent of 3.34.74 Hectare at Korukkai Village in Thiruthuraiipoondi Taluk in Thiruvallur District.	5,04,000.00

Schedule Downloading from website by Free of Cost: From 05.03.2026 to 12.03.2026 up to 3.00 P.M
Last Date for receipt of online tender: 12.03.2026 upto 3.00 P.M.
Date of Opening of Online tender: 12.03.2026 at 3.30 P.M.
For further details please visit website: [www.tenders.gov.in](#) DCPR/1562/TENDER/2026

Managing Director



Bullying Anthropic

The U.S.'s demands for maximum flexibility on AI use are dangerous

Over the last few days, the U.S. Department of Defence unceremoniously cast out the AI firm Anthropic, which develops the coding assistant Claude, and designated the firm a “supply chain risk”, the kind of cattle branding reserved for firms that are compromised by hostile foreign states. The reason was simple: Anthropic refused to relent on allowing its tools to be used for widespread domestic surveillance and fully autonomous weaponry. The high-octane conflict with the U.S. government – which accused Anthropic of following a “woke” and “radical” agenda – is a shocking escalation, despite prior concessions that would allow the U.S.'s defence establishment's use of Claude, which helps create and update code bases quickly. The conflict also sends a chilling message – a great power can do anything, with or without safeguards, to attain a strategic upper hand. This is a dangerous message to send in a multipolar world where shared standards around safety are increasingly difficult to achieve.

This is no longer the world of the Bletchley Park AI safety summit. It was a gathering that acknowledged the rapidly growing power of AI systems, and the shared global imperative to ensure that high-stakes risks be mitigated. What resonance does that worthy message have when the country on the frontier of AI development so publicly disavows any form of safety control for war, at a time when a reckless attack on Iran – with, reportedly, some assistance from Claude – is grinding on? Firms need to show some backbone when dealing with outrageous demands that could have chilling consequences in their home country and around the world. After all, if the U.S. demands the policy space for domestic surveillance in such a full-throated fashion, where does that leave countries where infiltrating the political opposition with spyware on their phones is already the norm? Anthropic showed this backbone, and it deserved the solidarity of its peers. Sadly, that is not what happened, as ChatGPT maker OpenAI appeared to give the U.S. defence department the flexibility it sought just hours after Anthropic became persona non grata. Despite OpenAI's assurances that its agreement provides key safeguards, AI safety has been harmed, with the other superpower and a host of middle powers around the world watching closely. Firms may not be the ideal characters to take a stand – taking into consideration, after all, their profit motivations – but as strong institutions are worn down around the world, there are few places to look to for leadership on safety. When a firm with billions of dollars at stake says ‘no’, it is not a promising sign of things to come when another steps in to say ‘maybe, yes’.

Reckless wreckers

Damaging nuclear facilities under an unstable regime poses great risks

Nuclear facilities have faced unprecedented threats of late. Since its capture by Russian forces in 2022, Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant has faced repeated shelling and drone strikes. While Russia wished to be the sole nuclear-armed successor to the Soviet Union, Israel has viewed Iran's nuclear programme as an existential threat and has attacked its weapons sites since 2024. In 2025, the U.S. launched targeted strikes against Fordow and Natanz, which enrich uranium, and Isfahan, a fuel cycle complex. U.S. President Donald Trump claimed they were “obliterated” but the IAEA found that the enriched uranium stockpile was largely intact at Isfahan. On March 2, the IAEA had said that the Bushehr and Tehran reactors had not been hit or damaged until then, although strikes on March 3 surfaced reports of damage to the Bushehr airport (according to Iran's state media) and again in Natanz. The broader pattern of attacking nuclear facilities is worrisome. Aside from overt attempts, at least one hacking attempt has breached the National Nuclear Security Administration, which manages the U.S.'s nuclear stockpile, while ransomware groups have targeted global energy firms and Brazil's state nuclear operator. The Geneva Conventions prohibit states from endangering nuclear facilities if they release “dangerous forces” but neither the U.S. nor Israel seems mindful of the risks. Iran has also accused the IAEA of spying for Israel.

Physically destroying a facility only removes one layer of risk; the humanitarian and environmental effects are often intractable. A damaged reactor core or spent fuel pool could release caesium-137, a long-lived isotope that causes acute radiation sickness and contaminates land for decades. Radioactive particles can be carried by winds, affecting global food security. Damaging nuclear facilities overseen by an unstable regime also risks loss of custody of enriched uranium. Such strikes do not achieve a strategic resolution and could in fact accelerate Iran's resolve, marked by its shift of assets to deeper, more clandestine facilities. Military force also destroyed the diplomatic and verification frameworks required for long-term safety, leaving negotiations as the safest way to restore stability in the region. Iran is already facing 60% inflation and the U.S. can trade sanctions relief for IAEA monitoring. Iran has also finalised long-term deals with Russia and China, in return securing air defences and navigation systems to negate western advantages, and bringing Tehran back to the table could also reduce its dependence on these burgeoning partnerships. Conversely, military action risks refugee exodus from a population of 93 million, asymmetric retaliation against the U.S.'s Gulf bases, and the inalienable threat of nuclear disaster.

The Tamil Nadu Assembly election is barely weeks away, and the seat-sharing deal between the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Congress has been sealed, with the Grand Old Party's high command agreeing to finalise the pact. This puts to rest what had been a dangerous temptation within sections of Congress – the idea that an alliance with actor-politician Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) could be a viable alternative to Congress's long-standing ties with the DMK.

This idea was cultivated by some second-rung leaders in the Congress for vituperative personal reasons and used by other partymen frustrated over seat-sharing issues as a bargaining chip, bringing the talks between the parties to a precipice of collapse. The alliance held, but the episode deserves examination, not just as a tactical question but also as one which is core to the meaning of progressive politics in Tamil Nadu and what is at stake to preserve it.

A new party and its political concerns

It is imperative to understand the nature of the fledgling force that the TVK is and what it stands for, while evaluating the Congress's near-dalliance with it. On September 27, 2025, 41 people, many from poor and marginalised backgrounds, were killed in a crowd crush at a TVK rally in Karur, central Tamil Nadu. The facts of the TVK's failure in organising the rally are not in dispute. For months, its rallies had been designed primarily to showcase frenzied crowds rather than communicate any substantive political message. Mr. Vijay's arrival in Karur was intentionally delayed by nearly seven hours to increase the crowd size. The organisers grossly underestimated attendance, expecting 10,000 people but the turnout exceeded over 25,000. The crowd waited for hours without basic provisions before the actor-politician spoke briefly and hastily left the venue, as did several of his party's lieutenants following the crowd crush.

Rather than accepting responsibility for what had happened, the TVK flooded social media with conspiracy theories suggesting sabotage, despite there being no evidence of this. Mr. Vijay himself made these claims. When the Madras High Court constituted a Special Investigation Team in October to investigate the case and made pointed observations about the TVK's conduct, the party successfully obtained a Supreme Court of India order transferring the probe to the Central Bureau of Investigation. During questioning in January 2026, Mr. Vijay claimed that he was “not responsible” for the stampede.

The party relies on whipping up mass hysteria as a means of mobilisation and promoting a personality cult rather than ideology. There is the token presence of visages of leaders such as Periyar, Ambedkar, and Kamaraj in backdrops at its rallies, but the party pays lip service to them. Its political project has been built more like a fan club than a democratic party. This is not a party that any force which is committed to



Srinivasan Ramani

The challenges in the Congress-DMK seat-pact discussions underscore that governance and alliance cohesion matter more than mere celebrity-driven political spectacle

constitutional values can meaningfully align with.

As this writer has previously argued in these pages, Tamil Nadu stands at a pivotal economic moment. It is India's second largest economy and is pursuing a transition from a middle-income economy to a high-value, innovation-driven model – a shift that requires sustained investment in research and development and diversified exports, which is possible only with good governance capacity and fiscal autonomy.

Politics and prosperity

The State's economic success has been built on the base of a distinct political culture. Its bipolar Dravidian system, for all its flaws of patronage and competitive populism, produced a governance model that combined industrialisation with welfare, and the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance, with its internal structure of mutual accountability between the Congress, the Left, the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), and the DMK, is well placed to deepen that model. The alliance's sweep of all 39 Lok Sabha seats in the 2024 general election was a consequence of the ideological coherence made possible by each party shedding old antipathies toward the others.

The Congress, by staying the course, has ensured that this coherence holds – at least for now. But the episode has exposed how fragile the structure can be when one of its pillars even entertained the thought that the alliance was dispensable. The DMK-led alliance is not merely a State-level arrangement; it is a critical link in the national opposition to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s centralising, majoritarian project. It is about demonstrating that an alternative to the BJP's politics of social engineering and minority-bashing can be not just morally necessary but also electorally viable. Had the Congress walked away, it would have broken a vital connection in the INDIA bloc, with Tamil Nadu being one of its strongest links.

What makes this alliance and Tamil Nadu's political culture more broadly worth fighting for is also the nature of voter choice in the State. Yes, a substantial number of the State's voters remain beholden to patronage and clientelism. But, there exists a significant and politically aware section of the electorate that has been shaped by decades of Dravidian mobilisation, rationalist movements, and a vibrant civil society spanning literature, cinema and popular culture. It stands with parties that are committed to social justice and decentralised power (federalism), and is willing to judge governments based on governance and performance rather than a mere pandering to identities of religion and caste.

This is in stark contrast to what is thriving in States across the north and west, where social engineering and the stoking of hate toward minorities have proven sufficient for parties to win elections, regardless of their record on jobs, public services or institutional integrity. Tamil Nadu has, thus far, resisted this straightjacketing of voter choices into narrow communal binaries,

Climate risks must prompt international legal reforms

So far, states have focused on addressing climate change's biophysical impacts and finding burden-sharing formulae that avoid serious socio-economic harm to developing and least-developed countries. The grave consequences of climate change are likely to prompt a renegotiation of some of the fundamentals of international law, including permanent sovereignty over natural resources (PSNR), requirement of territory for statehood, and unsettling of maritime zones.

The principle of PSNR is a fundamental right of states and peoples, which represents the resolve of developing countries to attain economic independence. Under the PSNR, a state has the right to extract fossil fuels above and below ground. The urgency to restrict global average temperature below 1.5° Celsius is giving rise to the demand among many states, scholars and policymakers to phase out fossil fuel. Scholarly writings increasingly support a Fossil-Fuel Non-Proliferation Treaty to keep large swathes of fossil fuels that remain in the ground

The issue of fossil fuels, first raised at COP 28 and again at COP 30 – even outside the formal agenda – highlights growing momentum for a phase-out. The developing countries may accept limited obligations impinging on PSNR towards a common concern of mankind but these must not be permanent or disregard the interests of high fossil-fuel-dependent nations. The limited obligations should be accompanied by developed countries providing sufficient finance and transferring carbon-neutral ‘best available technologies’ to developing nations

Climate change and territory

International law specifies that territory is a necessary prerequisite for statehood. The 1933 Montevideo Convention in Uruguay established



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Climate change may drive a renegotiation of key international law principles, including statehood territory and maritime zones

the four criteria of statehood – territory, permanent population, government, and the capacity to enter into relations with another state – as the benchmark for state recognition. Sea-level rise (SLR) threatening small island states poses the question of their continued statehood. Although the presumption of state continuity is unquestionably part of customary international law, several states are not categorical about its application to SLR. The International Court of Justice, in its advisory opinion, has said that once a state is established, the disappearance of one of its constituent elements would not necessarily entail the loss of its statehood. Scholars have described the ICJ's opinion on this aspect as a very modest legal claim.

In 2023, the Pacific Islands Forum (PIF) declared that international law does not contemplate its demise in the context of climate change-related SLR. Even the Montevideo Convention does not mention how much territory is to be lost to lose statehood. James Crawford, an authority on creation of state, is of the view that while a state must possess territory, there is no rule specifying a minimum size. Despite these arguments and legal claims, statehood generally remains precarious and often borderline.

The unprecedented risks to be faced by small-island states must prompt the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) to use the forum of the Conference of the Parties (COP) to apply equitable principles, addressing gaps in existing law beyond strict legal rules

Climate change-induced migration

In international law, the status of people who are likely to move to another country in the context of SLR is unclear. Such people also lose

a resistance that is one of the State's most valuable political assets.

Battle of ideologies

The promise of Tamil Nadu's relatively progressive politics is seen in the linking of welfare policies, even direct benefit transfers, with accountability for governance practices and government responsiveness. This is possible only when the political contest is predominantly one of principles and clear-cut ideologies, alongside being a referendum on governance. This is why governments have alternated between the Dravidian parties – the DMK and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) – and their respective alliances, a competitive dynamic in which constitutional values such as secularism and social justice have never come under fundamental threat or question.

Yet, even as this case for ideological coherence is made, there are worrying signs within the DMK-led alliance. The alliance's expansion to include the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), and O. Panneerselvam and his supporters, raise legitimate questions. The DMDK, drawing on a residual vote base from its founder, the late actor Vijayakanth, and O. Panneerselvam, a three-time Chief Minister under the AIADMK, whose political career has been shaped by patronage politics and a near-obsequious reliance on the BJP rather than ideological commitment, do not naturally fit into an alliance whose core constituents share a framework of social justice, secularism, and democratic accountability.

The logic behind these inductions is to do with realism and the additive accretion of support from sections backing these parties and individuals. In the short term, especially in a likely four-way contest with the TVK and Seeman's Naam Tamilar Katchi drawing votes, this arithmetic makes sense. But in the medium term, alliances that dilute ideology for marginal electoral gains risk affecting the distinctiveness of the progressive formation.

The DMK, for its part, must recognise that keeping the alliance's ideological core intact requires more than accommodating new entrants. This demands a new compact with its existing partners, one that shares not merely seats but also governance responsibilities, especially in local bodies.

In the end, the Congress made the right choice. Its future in Tamil Nadu and its national relevance as a force for progressive politics lies in strengthening its partnership with the DMK and the alliance's ideological core, rather than chasing the mirage of a personality cult. The 41 people who died in Karur remain a reminder of what personality cult politics costs. Tamil Nadu deserves a contest in which constitutional values are not subordinated to star power, unlike in a national polity increasingly defined by communal mobilisation.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A war beyond borders

Just a few days of strikes on Iran have already shown serious global consequences. From the loss of scores of lives in Iran, Lebanon and Israel, to flights being cancelled putting livelihoods in jeopardy and an energy crisis looming large with Saudi Arabia and Iraq suspending their oil

operations, there is much trouble ahead. That India has crude oil stocks to last for 25 days is also a double-edged sword. The irony is striking: U.S. President Donald Trump, who mediated failed Russia-Ukraine talks, is now caught in a ‘prolonged’ war. The inability of the United Nations to stop conflicts or hold nations accountable

stems from its reliance on member funding and lack of enforcement authority. If those in the Global South, Africa and Europe stand united against American ‘imperialism’, the U.S.'s sanctions, tariffs and bellicose posture cannot stand in the way of diplomacy for a just world. **Prabhu Raj R.,** Bengaluru

U.S. President Donald Trump is fighting a war against Iran with a cowboy mindset and misplaced bravado without realising the tragic consequences of war. He is basically an anarchist and an outlaw who cares little for international laws or the authority of global bodies such as the United Nations. He is fighting an illegal war

without mandatory Congress approval. He is safe in the distant United States but his allies in West Asia suffer the consequences with missile attacks from Iran. The economies of many countries will be hit hard by soaring oil prices. In his mistaken thinking, bombing is his obtuse solution to all problems.

Perhaps this absurd war is being staged, as some observers say, to shield himself from the devastating exposure of the Epstein Files. **Matthew Adukani,** Tirupattur, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

Lutyens and the politics of symbolism

On February 23, Edwin Lutyens's bust was removed as part of the government's ongoing decolonisation drive. In its place now stands the bust of C. Rajagopalachari, the first Indian Governor-General of independent India. Prime Minister Narendra Modi framed the move as an act of "leaving behind symbols of slavery," while the Opposition, predictably, criticised it in familiar and unimaginative terms. This is not the first time a statue – or in this case, a bust – has been taken down. Such acts are attempts to wreak vengeance on the past and rewrite the future.

There is no need to shed tears for Lutyens or what he represented. He is perhaps the only architect in modern history whose name has, for nearly a century, been synonymous with an entire city. Pierre Charles L'Enfant, who designed Washington D.C., has a handful of city landmarks named after him, such as a plaza, a metro station and promenades, in the city he shaped. His name as the city's architect was erased and resurrected only a century later. Today he lies buried in the Arlington cemetery overlooking the city, where he was interred 84 years after his death. Walter Burley Griffin, the Chicago architect who planned Canberra has a lake and a 276-km road named for him, but not a city.

The move to India
Lutyens was an ambitious man. At 19, with little architectural training, he struck out on his own. He was convinced of his talent; he was also aided by his social connections. His wife, Lady Emily, was the daughter of the Earl of Lytton, the former Viceroy of India. Lutyens had to turn to India because England was changing; an assertive middle class was elbowing the aristocracy out of power. High taxes on the wealthy introduced in 1909 meant fewer and fewer country houses to build. However, he hated India



Sobhana K. Nair

Lutyens ultimately secured near-exclusive credit for the city's design not just because he was talented, but because he was an exceptional public-relations strategist

and was uncharitable towards Indians. An unrepentant racist, he wrote to his wife Emily: "The Taj by moonlight becomes so bald and indefinite... It is wonderful but it is not architecture, and its beauty begins where architecture ceases to be." This was hardly an isolated remark. In another letter, Lutyens complaining about the ineptitude of Indian craftsmen, wrote mockingly, "... It will be difficult to find the men – Government ought to breed them! A job for the Eugenic societies!"

The Lutyens legacy
Lutyens was one of a three-member committee sent from London to select the site for New Delhi and later design it. When he arrived in Delhi, he had no experience in town planning. He was, fundamentally, a country-house architect who rose to prominence partly through brilliance and partly through influential social connections. He was not the sole architect of the capital; he shared responsibility with his friend-turned-rival Herbert Baker. He did not design the bungalows currently occupied by Parliamentarians that bear his name. Lord Hardinge, who spent months negotiating with Lutyens and the London bureaucracy on Delhi's design, has been erased from the city – Hardinge Avenue became Tilak Marg in the 1960s. Lutyens ultimately secured near-exclusive credit for the city's design not just because he was talented, but because he was an exceptional public-relations strategist. His friendship with the publisher of *Country Life*, a magazine devoted to English architectural beauty, ensured that nearly every house he designed received glowing coverage. Robert Byron's effusive praise of the Viceroy's House (now Rashtrapati Bhavan) in the 1931 *Architectural Review* further elevated his standing, even as Byron dismissed buildings such as the Parliament House, designed by Baker. But, there is no denying Lutyens's brilliance: he completed roughly

800 projects, an enviable body of work in both scale and variety.

Political jousting
It is unlikely that the government went into such minutiae before deciding to remove his bust. In the last century, his name has transitioned from an adjective to a pejorative. Any English-speaking liberal elite who benefitted from the old order is marked as 'Lutyens Elite'. Removing the Lutyens bust is also a measure of shadow-boxing with this elite. The decision to put Rajagopalachari's bust in his place is politically expedient for the ruling party in view of the upcoming Tamil Nadu Assembly polls, especially when it is supplemented by the narrative that Rajaji had been ignored by the previous Congress governments. Our pugilistic public discourse, of course, demands that we pick a side. The Opposition's response here was banal – lamenting that "whatever is left of Lutyens' design history will be broken down" and folded into a narrative of purging colonial remnants. Yes, preserving history matters. Successive governments have had a shameful track record with preserving history. Whatever monuments remain, often exist without any context. For the British did not build New Delhi out of generosity. They shifted the capital from Calcutta to consolidate the new King's authority and manage the political fallout from the partition of Bengal. Similarly, the Narendra Modi government did not begin redeveloping New Delhi during the COVID pandemic because there was a pressing urban need. Both the British and the Modi government were driven by the same impulse: to stamp their imprint on the city. Thus, the government's "decolonisation" effort is less about historical justice and more about shaping headlines. And that, ultimately, is the real story here – not Lutyens, but the politics of symbolism.

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Congress stuck in a quota matrix

The recruitment for government jobs in Karnataka has stirred a hornet's nest

STATE OF PLAY

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The announcement of the Congress government in Karnataka to have one of the largest recruitment drives in the State to fill up 56,432 posts to placate restive, unemployed youth has brought to the fore the complexities of reservation and has sharply divided Dalit communities. The government has announced that recruitment needs to be done with a cap on reservation at 50% that existed prior to December 2022. It has also given up on the newly provided internal reservation among the 101 Scheduled Castes (SCs) in the State. These two decisions have not gone down well.

The reservation complex
The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in 2022 through the Karnataka Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Reservation of Seats in Educational Institutions and of Appointments or Posts in the Services under the State) Act, 2022, had hiked reservations for SCs from 15% to 17% and for Scheduled Tribes (STs) from 3% to 7%. With 32% reserved for Other Backward Classes (OBCs), the total reservation in Karnataka went up to 56%. While this has been questioned in the High Court, experts have also pointed out that increasing reservation without Constitutional backing will lead to legal hurdles. With multiple cases in the Karnataka High Court – first against breaching the reservation quota the Supreme Court had capped at 50% to 56%, and later against the internal reservation matrix announced by the State government – hir-

ing had slowed down in the State. Moreover, in between, the State government had paused the hiring process for about a year to enable the H.N. Nagamohan Das Commission to collect empirical data and recommend the internal reservation matrix.

However, under pressure and amid protests by unemployed youth, the government took the decision to restart the hiring process within 30 days, but the Government Order capped reservation at 50% and did not account for internal quota, citing the ongoing cases in the High Court.

Ironically, the Congress government took the decision to not implement internal reservation in the current recruitment cycle on the day the Governor gave his assent to the Karnataka Scheduled Castes (Sub-Classification) Bill, 2025. It provides that the overall 17% reservation for the 101 SCs will be divided proportionally across three categories. Even before this Legislative action, nomadic communities among the SCs had approached the High Court, questioning the reservation matrix.

The Congress in its 2023 manifesto had promised the implementation of internal reservation. Now, stung by the government's decision, the Dalit left communities, which had fought for internal reservation for nearly four decades, have asked the government to fix internal quota within the

15% (before the 2022 Act) before any recruitment process is commenced. They argue that the benefits of reservation in public recruitment and education have been cornered by relatively well-off Dalit right (Holeyá and other castes) communities and the 'touchable' castes of Bhovi, Korama, Koracha and Lambani. The Federation of Madiga Sanghas (comprising Dalit left communities) has identified Dalit right castes as those "opposed to internal reservation" (Left and right here are mere categories and not ideologies).

Cabinet divide
The issue has also divided the Cabinet with Dalit right Ministers arguing against the internal reservation, prompting the Dalit left community leaders to seek the resignation of Social Welfare Minister H.C. Mahadevappa, a Dalit right leader, for being "biased." The two Dalit left Ministers in the Cabinet are also upset and have questioned Chief Minister Siddaramaiah over the "injustice." In Karnataka, Dalit right groups are seen as loyal to the Congress, while Dalit left communities are seen as having drifted to the BJP.

The move has also upset the STs who have issues with the overall reduction in reservation. Though the government has said that it will reserve an additional 2% to SCs and 4% for STs – subject to the outcome in Court – the STs see it as "eyewash" and argue that around 3,385 posts would go to the general category in the current recruitment cycle.

Stuck in this reservation vortex, the Congress government is likely to tread cautiously as the decision could later upset poll calculations, especially in north Karnataka where the ST and Dalit left population is high.

The quiet demographic revolution unfolding in India

India, long viewed as the archetype of a 'high-fertility developing country', has quietly become a relatively low-fertility society

DATA POINT

Bhargav B.S.
Arjun Jayadev

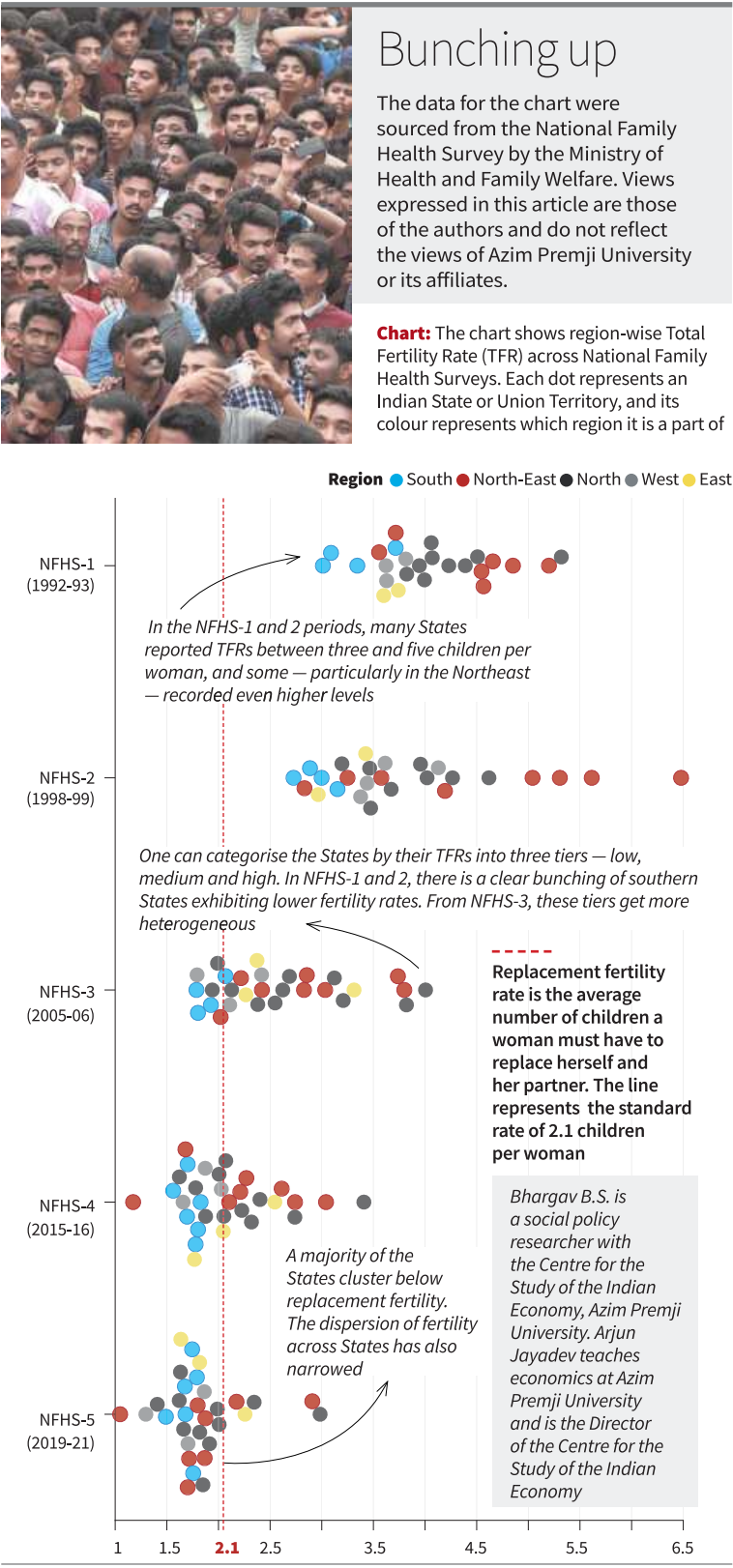
For much of the late 20th century, discussions of India's future were framed by a single anxiety: population growth. The assumption was that rapid fertility would outpace the economy's ability to generate food, infrastructure, and public services. The infamous "Population Bomb" thesis of Paul and Anne Ehrlich was a key text that informed public policy for decades. Over the last 25 years, India has experienced a fertility transition of extraordinary speed. Data from successive National Family Health Surveys (NFHS) show Total Fertility Rate (TFR) falling from levels near four children per woman in the 1990s to around replacement level, with most States now at or below 2.1 children per woman. The chart provides the sharpest indication of this. India, long viewed as the archetype of a 'high-fertility developing country', has quietly become a relatively low-fertility society. In the NFHS-1 and 2 periods, many States reported TFRs between three and five children per woman, and some – particularly in the Northeast – recorded even higher levels. By NFHS-3 and NFHS-4, fertility had dropped substantially. But the most striking change appears in NFHS-5, where a majority of the States cluster below replacement fertility. The dispersion of fertility across States has also narrowed, indicating convergence towards a low-fertility norm across India's regions. One can categorise the States by their TFRs into three tiers – low, medium and high. In NFHS-1 and 2, there is a clear bunching of southern States exhibiting lower fertility rates relative to central, northern and northeastern States. However, starting from NFHS-3, these tiers get more heterogeneous, where States from other re-

gions also begin to move into lower fertility categories. The northeastern States (except Tripura), Uttar Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Haryana, Punjab, and Rajasthan show the highest declines in fertility across the five rounds. Of the States that had relatively low fertility rates to begin with, Karnataka, West Bengal, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Odisha have the highest decline.

Significant transformation
Almost all scholars of the phenomenon have pointed to rising women's education and delayed marriage as proximate causes. As educational attainment rises, the expected returns to labour market participation increase, while the opportunity cost of early and repeated childbearing grows. Where the labour market offers meaningful opportunities, fertility tends to fall faster and where employment remains precarious, the transition proceeds more unevenly. A second factor could be the diffusion of new family-size norms through migration, urbanisation, and media exposure. The many decades of family planning messages may have contributed to such changes. Once smaller families become the social standard, fertility decline accelerates even where income levels or institutional conditions lag behind. Third, the decline reflects public health successes. Improvements in child survival reduced the need for 'precautionary fertility', the historical pattern in which families had more children to insure against high mortality. Vaccination programmes, maternal health services, and nutritional interventions have quietly reshaped reproductive behaviour by increasing the confidence that children will survive into adulthood. However, not all the reasons for this decline may be positive. It is also possible that the rising cost of raising children is a factor. As schooling, healthcare, and housing, become increasingly mone-

tised, children shift from being contributors to household production toward becoming intensive investment projects. Families that once relied on informal social arrangements now face a world in which upward mobility requires substantial expenditure on education and skill formation.

Myriad consequences
The first is that there is a "demographic dividend," in which the share of working-age people with low dependency ratios creates the potential for faster growth. Without a structural shift towards labour-absorbing industrialisation and public investment, the dividend risks being squandered. The second surrounds the political economy of fertility. Southern and western States, where fertility has been below replacement level for some time, are moving more rapidly towards aging populations. This divergence is likely to reshape patterns of internal migration, fiscal transfers, and political representation over the coming decades. The movement of younger workers from relatively poorer, higher-fertility regions to aging, lower-fertility regions may become one of the defining structural features of India's internal economy. For decades, population control programmes occupied a central place in development planning. Today, the more pressing need is the opposite: building the institutional foundations for a low-fertility society. This includes childcare, pension systems capable of supporting an aging population, healthcare systems oriented toward chronic rather than infectious disease burdens, and urban infrastructure able to accommodate continued migration and household transformation. India's demographic story is therefore no longer one of unchecked population growth. The key policy concerns now will be those of employment, aging, migration, and the social organisation of care.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 5, 1976

Attractions for U.S. tourists in India

Madras, March 4: India was one of the most promising destination points for future travel by American tourists, Mr. Dale Remington, President, New York Travel Writers Association, and Producer and Director of an American Television team, said to-day. Mr. Remington is on a 12-day tour of India as one of a 13-member group of American travel agents, travel writers and producers. The team led by Mr. M. Chudesama, Public Relations Manager, Air-India, New York, arrived in Bombay on February 28. Seven members of the team including Mr. James Vito, TV cameraman, left to-day for Trivandrum, after a three-day visit to the city. Mr. Remington told newsmen at the airport that so far people in the United States had been given mostly a negative impression of India – about starvation, poverty and other aspects. But his team wanted to show a real picture of the rural folk, how they lived and worked, depicting many facets of life. In Bombay, they had taken shots of horse races and in Madras they had made some TV films on pottery making, day-to-day life of fishermen, the monuments at Mahabalipuram, and the Snake Park at Guindy, which was being run very well.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 5, 1926

Frantic scenes in New York exchange

New York, March 4: Indescribable scenes were witnessed at the Stock Market as a result of a record slump in railway shares, hundreds and thousands of which were freely offered. Trading in the afternoon was done at a terrific pace, there being over 2 million sales during the first three hours alone. In the general scramble to execute orders brokers performed antics like dancing dervishes almost tearing off each other's clothing as they struggled around the various trading posts. Meanwhile tickers rattled at full speed but even after the first hour they were 18 minutes behind the market. Outside the brokerage offices were jammed with anxious crowd which fearfully watched the furious battle of bulls and bears indicated on the boards by a thousand clerks, many of whom had been working all night.

MVA leaders back Sharad Pawar for Rajya Sabha, unopposed election likely

Congress drops its claim after internal negotiations; allies to support Uddhav's bid in Legislative Council election; the BJP fields four candidates as alliance leaders cite seniority and unity in backing the senior NCP(SP) leader's nomination; Pawar's grandnephew Parth Pawar to file papers today

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Ending days of uncertainty in Maharashtra, the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) on Wednesday formally announced Sharad Pawar as its sole candidate for the coming Rajya Sabha election, raising the possibility of an unopposed contest in the State.

The Congress central leadership decided in favour of Mr. Pawar's candidature, giving up on its own claim and standing against Shiv Sena (UBT)'s demand. "The decision follows Shiv Sena (UBT)'s refusal to take a stand on the Congress's proposal for (a joint) alignment between the two parties (Congress and Shiv Sena UBT) for one candidate," a Congress source told *The Hindu*.

Second bid

"The MVA will now support Uddhav Thackeray for his second bid in the upcoming Legislative Council election," a senior Congress leader and a Shiv Sena (UBT) leader confirmed.

For the Rajya Sabha seat, the election quota in Maharashtra stands at 36



Clear picture: A file photo of NCP (SP) Chief Sharad Pawar, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Shiv Sena (UBT) Chief Uddhav Thackeray in Mumbai. EMMANUAL YOGINI

votes. Within the MVA, Shiv Sena (UBT) is the largest party with 20 MLAs, followed by Congress with 16 MLAs, and the NCP (SP) with 10. "Had the Shiv Sena (UBT) supported the Congress, we still had the strength to field one candidate. But Uddhav Thackeray did not respond to our proposal," a senior Congress leader said on condition of anonymity.

Several State Congress leaders expressed displea-

sure over the party not securing either the Rajya Sabha seat or the coming Maharashtra Legislative Council berth.

All three MVA constituents had initially staked claim to the Rajya Sabha candidature. The Congress argued that, as a national party, it needed a greater presence in the Rajya Sabha to strengthen its Leader of the Opposition position.

The Shiv Sena (UBT) maintained that as the single lar-

gest Opposition party in Maharashtra and given the alliance's principle of rotation, its claim was valid. The NCP(SP), meanwhile, contended that Mr. Pawar's stature would ensure an unopposed election.

Leaders from the Congress and the Shiv Sena (UBT) described the matter as having taken an emotional turn, with neither party keen to appear un-supportive of Mr. Pawar. "He is a senior leader and

Last day for filing nominations for the Rajya Sabha election is today. Polls are going to be held on March 16

unwell. He wants to be in the Rajya Sabha. Supriya Sule (Mr. Pawar's daughter), too, had been concerned about him. At such a juncture, not supporting him would have sent a wrong message to other allies. Mallikarjun Khargeji and Sonia Gandhiji decided that as the leader of the INDIA [Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance] bloc, we must support him," the sources said.

On Tuesday night, NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule, along with State unit president Jayant Patil, met Uddhav Thackeray for over two hours to discuss the issue.

BJP's stance

BJP sources had earlier indicated that the party would not field more than four candidates if Mr. Pawar was declared the MVA candidate. On Wednesday, the BJP announced four candidates: Union Minister

Ramdas Athawale, Vinod Tawde, Maya Invate and Ramrao Wadkute.

"I thank the Congress central leadership, State leaders, Uddhav Thackeray and his party and family for their support. We are truly grateful," Ms. Sule said.

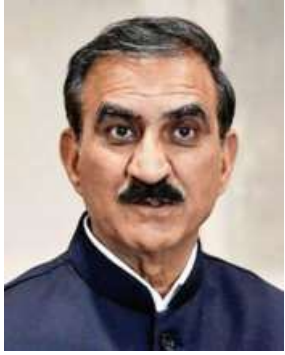
"The MVA will continue its fight against the BJP. Sharad Pawar going to the Rajya Sabha is a good indication," Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal said.

Meanwhile, Sharad Pawar's grandnephew Parth Pawar is set to file his nomination on Thursday as the NCP candidate from the ruling Mahayuti alliance. He is the son of the late NCP leader and Sharad Pawar's nephew Ajit Pawar, who was the Deputy Chief Minister when he died in a tragic air accident in January. Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena is expected to finalise its candidate on Thursday, the last day for filing nominations.

The Rajya Sabha elections are going to be held on March 16. Of the 37 seats from 10 States which will go to the polls, seven seats are from Maharashtra.

Congress candidate for RS polls will be named today: Sukhu

Press Trust of India
SHIMLA



Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu

Name of the Congress candidate for the lone Rajya Sabha seat from Himachal Pradesh will be disclosed at the time of filing of nomination on Thursday, Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said on Wednesday.

The candidate will be from Himachal Pradesh, he told presspersons here.

Thursday is the last date for filing of nomination for the Rajya Sabha and polling will be held on March 16. The election is needed as the six-year term of Bharatiya Janata Party leader Indu Goswami, elected unopposed in 2020, is coming to an end.

"There is neither any suspense nor fear over the election," Mr. Sukhu said, asserting that democracy would not be "sold like previous time".

Past experience

With a clear majority in the 68-member Himachal Pradesh Assembly, the Congress's victory is a foregone conclusion, but the party is haunted by its bitter experience in the previous Rajya Sabha election, where it lost the seat to the BJP despite having 40 MLAs and the backing of three

Independents.

In the last election in February 2024, BJP candidate Harsh Mahajan defeated the Congress's Abhishek Manu Singhvi after they ended in a tie as six Congress MLAs cross-voted in favour of the BJP. The three Independents also voted against the Congress, and both candidates polled 34 votes each.

At present, there are 40 members of the Congress and 28 members of the BJP in the Assembly. A meeting of the Himachal Pradesh Congress Legislature Party has been convened on Thursday.

So far, neither the Congress nor the BJP has announced their candidates and BJP leaders have maintained that they would field a candidate only if the Congress candidate is not from Himachal Pradesh.

Raijor Dal releases first list of 11 candidates for Assam polls; CM slams Cong's list

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Raijor Dal, led by Akhil Gogoi, released its first list of 11 candidates for the coming Assam Assembly election on Wednesday, less than 24 hours after its ally, the Congress, announced its first list of 42 candidates.

The election to the 126-member House is expected to be held in April.

The Raijor Dal has fielded Rahul Chetry from this eastern Assam seat, where the Congress has nominated Prateek Bordoloi, the son of Pradyut Bordoloi, MP for Nagaon. The party has also nominated Abdur Rashid Mandal from the Goalpara East constituency in western Assam. A three-time Congress MLA, he switched to the Raijor Dal a few weeks ago.

Among the 11 candidates, Raijor Dal's working president Romen Chandra Borthakur will contest the Jalukbari seat. Gyanashree Bora, named from the Dig-



Akhil Gogoi

boi constituency, is the lone woman in the list.

The Raijor Dal has indicated that it could field candidates in at least eight more constituencies where the Congress has named its nominees, suggesting that the two parties are yet to resolve differences over seat sharing.

'Hereditary politics'

Reacting to the Congress list, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said it reflected the "hereditary politics" of the party. "If you analyse the list of candidates released by the As-

sam Pradesh Congress Committee, it becomes clear that they have been selected based on dynasty and family politics," he said.

Pointing to the sons of three former Chief Ministers in the list, Mr. Sarma took a swipe at the Congress for not looking beyond the descendants of its leaders.

The Congress candidates he referred to are Gaurav Gogoi, MP from Jorhat, Debabrata Saikia, and Diganta Barman, contesting the Jorhat, Nazira, and Barkhetry seats, respectively. They are the sons of former Chief Ministers Tarun Gogoi, Hiteswar Saikia, and Bhumidhar Barman.

The list includes many political heirs, including the sons of Rakibul Husain and Pradyut Bordoloi, as well as the son of former Union Minister Paban Singh Ghatowar and the daughter-in-law of former MLA Membor Gogoi, underscoring a strong hereditary trend in the list.

No possibility of merger of NCP factions any more, our position is clear, says Jayant Patil

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

The Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) on Wednesday formally scotched speculation about a possible merger with the Nationalist Congress Party, saying that such talks were no longer under consideration and that its allies in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) were aware of the party's position.

Speaking to presspersons in Mumbai, NCP(SP) State president Jayant Patil said, "The merger talks

had been initiated at the insistence of Ajit Pawar. He is no more now. So there is no possibility of a merger any more. This issue does not exist any more. I don't think any of our alliance partners have any doubts about this."

His remarks come amid concerns raised by some MVA leaders about the NCP(SP)'s ideological position and whether it might eventually align with the BJP-led Mahayuti in Maharashtra.

Ajit Pawar, Deputy Chief Minister of Maharashtra and NCP's national presi-

NCP(SP) leader says the plan does not exist any more as Ajit Pawar, who initiated it, is dead

dent, died in a tragic air crash on January 28. Following his death, the NCP (SP) had claimed that merger talks between the two factions were at an advanced stage and that a formal announcement was expected on February 12. However, the party did not clarify whether a unified NCP would align with the

National Democratic Alliance's regional alliance Mahayuti or INDIA [Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance] bloc's regional alliance MVA. This ambiguity had triggered unease among its allies.

On alliance partners

Mr. Patil spoke on the sidelines of discussions over the Rajya Sabha nomination from Maharashtra. When asked whether alliance partners were seeking assurance about the NCP(SP)'s allegiance to the INDIA bloc, the senior leader said no such assu-

rance was necessary.

The party maintained that the MVA was formed at the initiative of Sharad Pawar and that he remained the binding force that brought the Congress and the Shiv Sena together despite their years of political differences.

The NCP(SP) has maintained that Ajit Pawar had been keen on reunification and had initiated informal discussions without consulting other party leaders. However, the current leadership of the NCP has denied that any merger talks were under way.

MALABAR INTERNATIONAL PORT & SEZ LTD
INVITATION OF TWO EXPRESSIONS OF INTEREST
EXTENDED UP TO 1st JUNE, 2026, 1700 hrs (IST)

1. **Development, Operation & Maintenance of the Greenfield Malabar International Port, on Public Private Partnership** (INR 3429 Cr (\$ 452.2 M)).

2. **Construction & Maintenance of Breakwaters on EPC-Hybrid Annuity** (INR 1428 Cr (\$ 188.34 M)).

Details -Website: malabarport.kerala.gov.in
Email: mdapl.port@kerala.gov.in
MD & CEO, MIPS Ltd., N-5, Jawahar Nagar, Trivandrum-695003, KERALA
03/237/2026/I & PRD

**GOVERNMENT OF INDIA-DEPARTMENT OF SPACE
CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC –SHAR
SRIHARIKOTA-524124**

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE
e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/258731 Date: 03/03/2026
On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following works:

Sl.No.	Brief Name of work	Est. Value (Rs)
1	Shoreline Protection Measures (Construction of 10 nos. of Groynes) for about 2.20 kms on northern side of Sriharikota Island, SDSC SHAR	3547 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) up to 26/03/2026 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro> .
Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

**KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD**
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar,
Bengaluru – 560 009. Phone No. 080-22265383. Website: www.kiadb.in

No.: IADB/ENGG/ENTD-EP-29/01775/2025-26 Date:04.03.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item rate Tender is invited as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors Registered in KPWD who have got adequate financial resources & sufficient past experience for the following work as per the schedule given below:

Name of the Work: Providing Over Head Height Barrier at Various Locations at kadechur Badiyal Industrial Area, Yadgiri District (3rd Call).

The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **16.03.2026 upto 04:00 pm.**

Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

**Sd/-
Chief Engineer - 2**

No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-DPR-06/01774/2025-26 Date:04.03.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

KIADB invites tender from reputed consultants / firms under two cover bid system having an office at Bengaluru with vast experience and proven record of similar nature of work for project mentioned below:

Name of the Work : Providing Consultancy Services for preparation of Detailed Project Report (DPR) for Scientific Disposal of Industrial Solid Watse by Integrated Material Recovery Facility (MRF) and Alternate Fuel Raw Material Facility (AFR) including survey, analysis, qualitative & quantitative study, design of MRF & ARF facility etc., at plot No. 311 to 314, Belur Industrial Area, Dharwad Taluk & District (3rd Call).

The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **16.03.2026 upto 04:00 pm.**

Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

**Sd/-
Chief Engineer - 2**

DIPR/CP/JA/5992/2025-26

"Notification for selection to the position of Executive Vice President Kerala State Council for Science, Technology and Environment published and the details are available on the following Websites of Kerala State Planning Board (www.spb.kerala.gov.in), Kerala State Council for Science, Technology and Environment (www.kscste.kerala.gov.in) and Government of Kerala (<https://kerala.gov.in>)"

**SANJAY GANDHI INSTITUTE OF
TRAUMA AND ORTHOPAEDICS**
(Government of Karnataka Autonomous Institute)

Byrasandra, Jayanagar East, Bengaluru - 560 011 Ph: 080-26564516,
26562500 Grams: SITO Fax: 26565222 E-mail: sitodirector@gmail.com
No. SGITO/e-Tender/ME/06/07/08/2025-26) Date: 02-03-2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPP Portal only)

Sanjay Gandhi Institute of Trauma & Orthopaedics, Byrasandra, Jayanagar East, Bengaluru - 11 invites tender from the eligible tenderers through the KPP portal of GOK for procurement of below mentioned Medical equipments:-

(A). Tender No. SGITO/e-Tender/ME/Cautery/others/06/2025-26
(1) **HIGH END ELECTROSURGICAL EQUIPMENT — 4 Nos.**
(2) **O.T TABLE WITH ORTHOPAEDIC ATTACHMENTS — 1 No.**
(3) **MOTORIZED PATIENT COT WITH MATTRESS — 9 Nos.**

(B). Tender No. SGITO/e-Tender/ME/Monitors/07/2025-26
(1) **HIGH END MULTIPARA MONITORS — 4 Nos.**
(2) **MULTIPARA MONITORS- 18 Nos.**

(C). Tender No. SGITO/e-Tender/ME/Anaesth/workstation/08/2025-26
(1) **ANAESTHESIA WORK STATION — 2 Nos.**

(D). Tender No. SGITO/e-Tender/Pest Control/06(B)/2025-26
PEST CONTROL SERVICES

(1) The Tenderers can download the documents from: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/> on or after **04-03-2026** and the last date for submission of completed tenders through kpp portal is **20-03-2026 upto 4:00 PM.**

(2) The Tender Accepting Authority reserves the right to accept / reject or cancel tender without assigning any reason thereof.

**Sd/- Director
Tender Inviting Authority**

DIPR/SI/5982/2025-26

INBRIEF



Finland's President Stubb kicks off 4-day visit to India

Finnish President Alexander Stubb began a four-day visit to India on Wednesday to shore up bilateral cooperation across a wide spectrum of areas, including trade, investment and critical technology. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, welcoming Mr. Stubb, said his visit will take India-Finland relations to “new heights”. Mr. Stubb will hold talks with Mr. Modi on Thursday, following which the two sides are expected to firm up a number of agreements to boost cooperation. The Finnish president will be the chief guest at the inaugural session of the Raisina Dialogue on Thursday evening.

Row erupts after non-tribals barred from Meghalaya polls

A notification barring non-tribal people from contesting the April 10 elections to the Garo Hills Autonomous District Council (GHADC) has stoked controversy in Meghalaya. Garo tribal organisations have defended the notification, which makes it mandatory for all candidates to possess a Scheduled Tribe, or ST, certificate. Non-tribal leaders have slammed the notification as an unconstitutional move. Former legislator S.G. Esmatur Mominin questioned the legality of the notification, arguing that the GHADC lacks constitutional authority to impose such a condition. Enamul Haque, an aspiring candidate for the Balachanda constituency, pointed out that the notification was based on the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution.

India ranks second globally in childhood obesity: study

China, India and the U.S. each have over 10 million children with obesity; the World Obesity Atlas report highlights risk factors such as poor physical activity levels and sub-optimal breastfeeding

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

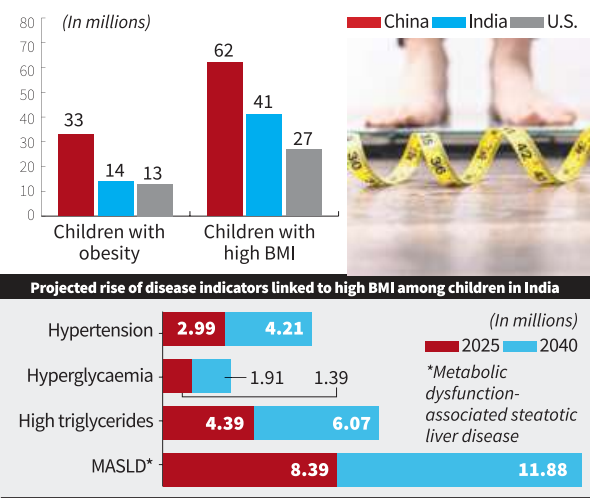
Nearly 15 million children aged five to nine and more than 26 million children aged 10 to 19 in India were overweight or obese in 2025, according to the World Obesity Atlas, 2026 released on World Obesity Day, which falls on March 4.

The World Obesity Federation, a global organisation focused on obesity, warned that the world was set to miss the 2025 global target to halve the rise in childhood obesity. Though the deadline is now being extended to 2030, most countries remain off track, and India is no exception, it said.

Over 200 million school-age children aged five to 19 who are overweight and living with obesity are concentrated in just 10 countries across the world. By the end of 2025, eight countries were projected to have over 10 million children with high Body Mass Index (BMI). China, India and the United States each had over 10 million children living with obesity. India stood second only to China in the num-

Worrying trend

The World Obesity Atlas found that more than one in five (20.7%) children worldwide are living with obesity and are overweight, and this number is only set to rise



ber of children with high BMI (41 million high BMI; 14 million obesity). China led the two categories with 62 million children with high BMI and 33 million with only obesity. The U.S. had 27 million children with high BMI and 13 million with obesity.

This rise in childhood obesity is expected to have serious health consequences. The Atlas pointed out that in India, the number of children with disease indicators linked to

high BMI is projected to rise substantially by 2040.

The report also highlighted several preventable risk factors across different age groups in the country. It noted that 74% of adolescents aged 11 to 17 failed to meet recommended physical activity levels, while only 35.5% of school-age children (primary and secondary) receive school meals. Nearly 32.6% of infants aged one to five months experience sub-optimal breastfeeding.

Among women aged 15 to 49, 13.4% have high BMI and 4.2% live with Type 2 diabetes. Children aged six to 10 consumed sugary drinks, averaging up to 50 ml per day. The Atlas found that over one in five (20.7%) children worldwide are living with obesity and are overweight. This was an increase from 14.6% in 2010. The Federation predicts that by 2040, a total of 507 million children will be living with obesity or be overweight.

Call for action

There is an emphasis on governments to act immediately. Johanna Ralston, chief executive of the World Obesity Federation, said, “The increase in childhood obesity worldwide shows we have failed to take seriously a disease that affects one in five children. Governments urgently need to step up prevention and management efforts for children living with overweight and obesity, and ensure that they receive the care they need.”

It has called for strong action to reverse current trends, including taxes on sugar-sweetened beverages and restrictions on marketing to children.

Study flags poor website-blocking practices in India

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

A largely unprecedented probe into the website blocking practices of multiple Indian Internet service providers (ISPs) has revealed inconsistencies in how sites are restricted across the country, and uncovered potentially clumsy practices that have led to large swaths of the web being blocked.

“A total of 43,083 unique apex domains were confirmed blocked via DNS filtering – a six-fold increase over the previous largest study (which documented 6,787 blocked domains),” researcher Karan Saini wrote in the report, “Poisoned wells: examining the scale of DNS censorship in India”, released on Monday. Over 23 crore domain names were tested. The report was supported by the Washington, DC-based Open Technology Fund’s Information Controls Research Program, hosted at Georgia Institute of Technology.

Of the over 43,000 individual URLs blocked across different networks, very few were universally restricted. For instance, Mr. Saini found that only 40% of websites flagged for militant and terrorism-related content were blocked

Study says Internet providers have little consensus when it comes to web blocking

by all the sampled providers: ACT Fibernet, MTNL, Airtel, Jio, Connect Broadband and YOU Broadband. Other categories have even less blocking implemented by all the sampled providers, such as pirated films and TV sites (4.54%), pornography sites (0.53%) and gambling sites (13.48%).

Blocking strategies

“A significant portion of web censorship in India relies on DNS filtering,” Mr. Saini writes. Domain Name System (DNS) filtering is subject to straightforward circumvention, while other methods, like server name inspection, have been more effective.

“The legal framework for censorship does not mandate any specific traffic filtering mechanisms,” he writes. “ISPs are free to choose and implement traffic filtering mechanisms according to their own technical abilities and operational needs. A direct consequence has been that users perceive and experience website blocking inconsistently.”

Solve confusion in delivering items addressed to the dead, Madras High Court tells India Post

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has directed the Union Ministry of Communications and the Director-General of Postal Services (DGPS) to solve the confusion over delivery of items addressed to dead persons due to an interplay between two provisions of the Post Office Regulations.

First Division Bench of Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava and Justice G. Arul Murugan have requested Additional Solicitor-General A.R.L. Sundaresan to send a copy of their order to the DGPS for compliance and further action as may be necessary to solve the confusion.

Till then, the postal department must hand over all items addressed to dead persons to their legal heirs, if the latter were found at

the given residence, the Division Bench ordered while disposing of a writ petition to strike down Regulation 51 of the Post Office Regulations, 2024.

Return to sender

Mohana Ramaswami of Chinnai Neelankarai in Chennai had filed the writ petition on the prime ground that the postal department was not handing over to her, the letters and other articles addressed to her deceased husband and instead returning them back to the senders.

Her counsel R. Subramanian brought it to the notice of the court that the DGPS had framed the Post Office Regulations, 2024 in exercise of the powers conferred on the officer under Section 13 of the Post Office Act, 2023. The regulations came into force on December 16, 2024.



Until there's clarification, items of deceased persons should be handed over to the legal heirs.

Regulation 51 states that items addressed to deceased persons must be treated as if they were unclaimed and disposed of as per Regulation 65(2). Further, Regulation 65(2) states that undelivered items must be sent back to the sender or the authorised person concerned, counsel pointed out.

However, the judges wrote “the provision (Reg-

ulation 51), in terms, does not appear to be suffering from any arbitrariness, much less manifest arbitrariness, warranting interference of this court”. They said a confusion appears to have arisen because of interplay between Regulation 51 and 65(1)(c).

The Division Bench pointed out Regulation 65(1)(c) clearly states that “an undelivered item of which the addressee is dead and there is no person to whom the item could properly be delivered, shall not be detained in the post office to which it is addressed and shall be returned to the sender.”

Legal interpretation

Laying stress on the words “if there is no person to whom the item could properly be delivered”, found in Regulation 65(1)(c), the judges said, a fair and logi-

cal interpretation of the regulations should only mean that the items should be returned to the sender only if they could not be handed over to legal representatives.

The Chief Justice added: “The Regulation does not expressly provide as to the category of persons to whom the item can properly be delivered. There appears to be a gap and this is causing inconvenience to persons like the writ petitioner.”

His Bench directed the Ministry and the DGPS to either amend the 2024 Regulations to define the category of persons to whom the items could be delivered or fill in the gap by clarifying the position properly. Till then, all postal items must be handed over to legal heirs found at the residence of the deceased, the court ordered.

Omar's meeting with civil society focuses on peace in Kashmir

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Wednesday chaired a meeting of legislators, religious leaders, and civil society groups to coordinate efforts in maintaining peace in Kashmir.

Mr. Abdullah had interacted with religious leaders and members of civil society in Srinagar in light of recent developments in West Asia, an official spokesperson said. “The participants [at the meeting] expressed concern over the situation and conveyed their condolences over the loss of lives in Iran.”

During the meeting, Mr. Abdullah emphasised the importance of maintaining peace and harmony in J&K while respecting the sentiments of the people, and ensuring that expressions

He stresses on maintaining harmony while expressing grief over recent events in Iran

of grief and mourning were peaceful and responsible, officials said.

Mr. Abdullah also offered *fatiha* (special prayers) for the slain Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and all those who had lost their lives in the recent developments in Iran.

Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti, meanwhile, burnt pictures of U.S. President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to register her party's protest against the killing of Khamenei and his family.

Former MP and veteran journalist H.K. Dua dead

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

H.K. Dua, former editor of three leading national dailies and Rajya Sabha member, passed away on Wednesday after a brief period of illness. He was 88.

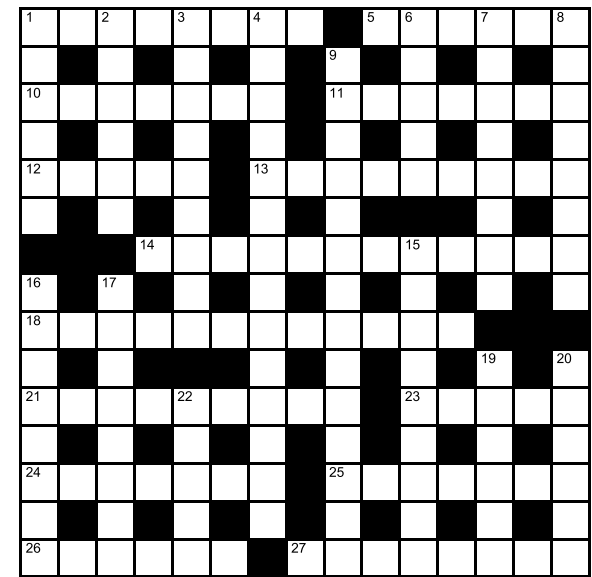
The veteran journalist breathed his last at a private hospital where he had been undergoing treatment for the past three weeks. The cremation will take place at the Lodhi Road crematorium on Thursday.

Apart from the distinction of serving as the Editor of *The Hindustan Times* (1987-94), and Editor-in-Chief of *The Indian Express* (1994-96) and *The Tribune* (2003-09), he also worked as the media adviser to two former Prime Ministers, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and H.D. Deve Gowda.

THCROSSWORD+14733

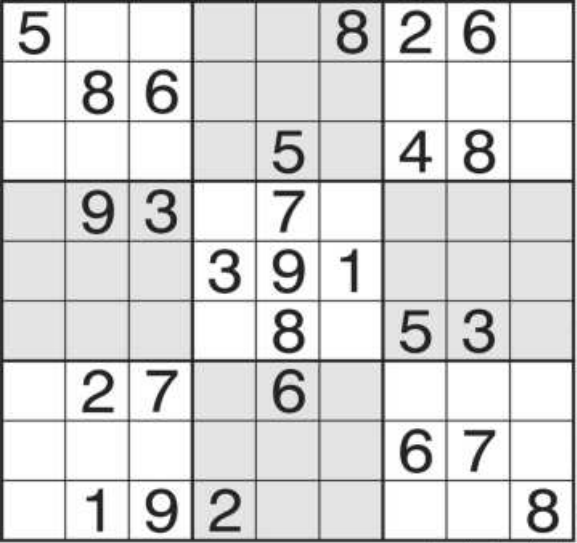
Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 14 One seen at racecourse painting popular horse during ceremony (8,4)
- 18 What person might do in cold weather to show keen satisfaction (3,4,5)
- 21 Immorality of English rogue enthralled by joint and cocaine on vacation (9)
- 23 Obstructive problem in part of small intestine, nearly ending in peritonitis (5)
- 24 Crowd heartily entertained by genius playing type of rock (7)
- 25 Crack cocaine - extremely repulsive bad habit (7)
- 26 Gemstone in store, mostly a little topaz (6)
- 27 Despise rogue having love affairs (8)
- Down**
- 1 Australian pal caught thief right away (6)
- 2 Being ethical, admits fault finally (6)
- 3 Misleads essentially in uncertainty, playing only two cards of a suit (9)
- 4 Incompetence of masseur in the spa, extremely clumsy (14)
- 6 A posh valuable, mostly of gold (5)
- 7 Comic in Cairo, ultimately satirical and wry (8)
- 8 Overweight guide, terribly exhausted (8)
- 9 Trump is beginning to argue at once, making fuss about trivial matter (5,2,1,6)
- 15 Singles romping, having party in retreat? Goodness! (9)
- 16 Resenting misuse of drug and drink by girl (8)
- 17 Old boy on screen, turning more indecent (8)
- 19 Crew in department checking VCR button (6)
- 20 They question fool grabbing king and queen (6)
- 22 Decided to acquire manufacturer's latest unmanned aerial vehicle (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

N	A	M	I	B	I	A	C	O	H	A	B	I	T
E	A	P	A	L	M	U	A	I	U				
C	O	Y	P	A	B	B	U	B	L	E	J	E	T
K	F	F	U	E	I	O							
T	E	L	E	F	I	L	M		T	R	U	E	
I	D	O		A		O							
E	D	W	I	N		N	E	W	S	T	A	N	
M	A	R	E	S	N	E	S	T		S	E	R	
L	O	O	F	A		T	R	I	T	A	T	E	
M	N												
S	H	A	N	G	R	I	L	A		P	R	I	
E	I												
Y	A	R	D	A	R	M		N	U	R	S	E	

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

8	1	9	5	6	3	2	4	7
5	6	2	9	4	7	8	1	3
4	7	3	8	1	2	6	5	9
7	9	1	2	3	5	4	6	8
3	5	6	4	8	9	7	2	1
2	4	8	6	7	1	3	9	5
9	8	7	1	2	4	5	3	6
6	2	5	3	9	8	1	7	4
1	3	4	7	5	6	9	8	2

FAITH

Controlling the mind key

Can a person enamoured by a shadow ever hope to catch it, when its very nature is illusory? Worldly pleasures are like shadows – appearing attractive, yet lacking substance. By running after them, one can never attain lasting peace or true happiness, for they are impermanent and fleeting. Therefore, we must not allow our minds to be driven by unchecked influence from the physical senses; instead, we must anchor them in restraint, clarity, and discernment. Lord Krishna says in the Bhagavad Gita that when the mind follows the wandering senses and indulges in their objects, a person's understanding is swept away – just as a ship on the ocean is carried off its course by a strong wind.

In a discourse, Thanneerpalli Sri Krishnan Swami emphasised that one should not allow the mind to run after worldly objects, but instead turn it inward toward self-realisation. Echoing this teaching, Krishna declares in the Gita that we should engage in actions that constantly remind us of Him. Such actions are not arbitrary; they are those enjoined by the Srutis and Smritis. By performing prescribed duties with remembrance of the Lord, the mind is purified, disciplined, and gradually led away from illusion toward true knowledge of the Self. If we engage in actions that are ultra vires the Sastras and Smritis and yet pray to God, it is doubtful whether such worship will truly please Him. Prayer cannot compensate for conduct that contradicts scriptural injunctions. True devotion lies in aligning one's actions with what is ordained by the Sastras and Smritis; only then does prayer become sincere, meaningful, and acceptable to God.

CM
YK

World No. 1 Sabalenka backs ‘best of five’ Slam proposal

Gauff and Swiatek are against the idea, which was floated by incoming USTA chief Tiley at the Australian Open last year

TENNIS

Agence France-Presse
INDIAN WELLS

World No.1 Aryna Sabalenka on Tuesday voiced her support for a proposal to make women's matches best-of-five sets during the later stages of Grand Slam tournaments.

Speaking ahead of this week's ATP-WTA tournament in Indian Wells, the hard-hitting Sabalenka said she believed switching to five sets would benefit her game.

"Yeah, let's do that," the four-time Grand Slam singles champion said when asked about the idea, which was floated by incoming US Tennis Association chief Craig Tiley at the Australian Open earlier

this year. "I feel like I would have probably more Grand Slams," Sabalenka added. "Physically I'm really strong, and I'm pretty confident that my body can handle that. So let's do it."

While Sabalenka backed the move, other women players were more circumspect. "I mean, it probably would favour me, because I'm physically up there with the best, but I mean, I probably wouldn't want to see that happen," Coco Gauff told reporters.

Six-time Grand Slam champion and former World No. 1 Iga Swiatek was firmly against the idea.

"I think honestly it's a weird approach in the world where everything is becoming faster," Swiatek said. "So I don't know if the audience honestly would like that."



Welcome change: Sabalenka believes she can win a lot more if the new proposal is implemented. AP

European Tour is extorting players: Rahm

Associated Press
LONDON

Jon Rahm tore into the European Tour over its offer for him and other LIV Golf players to rejoin, claiming the Tour was "extorting players" by forcing them to play additional tournaments.

Rahm, competing this week in LIV Golf Hong Kong, spoke publicly for the first time since the European tour announced a deal that would require LIV players to pay previous fines for not getting releases and to compete in additional events designated by the tour.

Eight players from LIV, including Tyrrell Hatton, accepted the deal. Rahm did not. "I don't know what game they're trying to play right now," Rahm said. "But it just seems like in a way they're using our impact in tournaments and fining us and trying to benefit both ways from what we have to offer. In a way, they're extorting players like myself and young players that have nothing to do with the politics of the game.

"So I don't like the situation and I'm not going to agree to that."

Players are required to play four tournaments, not including the majors, to keep membership on the European Tour. Rahm said the deal would have required LIV members to play six tournaments.

Stefanini cites threats before the Indian Wells qualifier

Associated Press
ROME

Italian tennis player Lucia Stefanini said she and her family were threatened when she received a text message featuring a photo of a gun before a qualifying match for the Indian Wells tournament in California – in an apparent attempt to affect the result for betting purposes.

Stefanini explained what happened in a video posted on Instagram on Monday from the BNP Paribas Open.

"I received a WhatsApp message in which I was threatened over winning yesterday's match. They threatened me and my family and named my parents, the place where I was born and they sent me a photo of a gun," Stefanini said.

"I don't think it's right to put me under this pressure and unease before a match," Stefanini said. "I immediately alerted the WTA, which provided me with more security."

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

M R KANAKAVALLI (86), wife of late M. Ramaratnam, The Hindu (ret'd), attained acharyan tiruvadi on March 4. Last rites at B-107, 3rd Main Rd, Nanganallur, Chennai- 61. Ct: 9884198194

Mrs. B. RATHINAMMAL (83), Mother of Ms. R. Vijayalakshmi, Chennai-600033, expired on 03-03-2026. Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai- 17 (Ph: 28340500).

OBITUARY



K. JAYARAMACHANDRAN (90 years, formerly Chief Engineer at Engineers India Ltd.) Viswanitra Gotram and lineage of scholar Ratnaksheta Srinivasa Dikshitar, passed away on 28th February, 2026. Mourned by wife, two daughters, grandson and brothers.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



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AROUND THE CITY

TN enters final

Pacer G. Govinath picked up five for 41 as Tamil Nadu bowled out Chhattisgarh for 182 in its second innings and won by 180 runs on day four of the Col. C.K. Nayudu Trophy Elite semifinal in Raipur on Wednesday. TN will face Maharashtra in the final, to be played from March 9 at Dindigul.

The scores:

Tamil Nadu 322 & 226 in 80.2 overs (S.R. Athish 51, K.T.A. Madhava Prasad 37, R.K. Jayant 31, P. Vignesh 38, Varun Singh Bhuike 3/75) bt Chhattisgarh 186 & 182 in 30.4 overs (Shobhit Sharma 34 n.o., Deepak Yadav 31, G. Govinath 5/41, P. Vignesh 4/66).

St. Bede's triumphs

St. Bede's AIHSS beat St. John's Public School (Perumbakkam) by one wicket in the final to clinch the PHCA Trophy u-14 inter-school championship title.

The scores (final):

St. John's Public School, Perumbakkam 113/7 in 25 overs (Mitran Pradeep 43 n.o.) lost to St. Bede's AIHSS 116/9 in 23.5 overs.



Govinath (Tamil Nadu, 5/41), D. Ram Singh (Rider CC, 6/19).



Aryan Sanjay Thakre (Krish CC, 5/22), S. Ganesh (Vijay CC, 145).



Ram Singh scalps six in Rider CC's win

D. Ram Singh's six for 19 enabled Rider CC beat Syndicate Nanganallur by 15 runs in a first division A-zone contest of the DCAC league.

The scores: I-A:

Rider 188 in 43.1 overs (Narayana Prasad 57, V. Sathyanarayanan 4/34) bt Syndicate Nanganallur 173 in 36.3 overs (N. Aakash Sharma 74, D. Ram Singh 6/19). Guru Nanak Combines 202 in

40.4 overs (Ravikumar 48, Shrirangan 42, Bharath 3/15, Haashid Farhaan 3/40) lost to Spring Field 203/6 in 29.4 overs (Aravind Vedhagiri 60, Viraj 55, Gopal 37 n.o., Sanjeevan 3/37).

Vijay 330/6 in 45 overs (R.S. Mokit Hariharan 84, S. Ganesh 145, Leela Sai 3/50) bt SRM IST 184 in 29.4 overs (Vignesh S. Iyer 36, Bharath Srinivas 55 n.o., Sachin Anand 34, D.T. Chandrasekar 4/30).

Venugopal 163 in 44.3 overs (E. Gokul 49, T. Aswinraj 31, P. Sreekumar 50, Aryan Sanjay Thakre 5/22) lost to Krish 164/7 in 29.2 overs (Vibhav Venkataraman Veliyur 31, P.C. Rohit 34).

II-A: Phoenix 167 in 29 overs (C.P. Akshath 68, A.C. Prathinraj 39, N.V. Vishnu Vardhan 4/39) bt Leo 74 in 20.3 overs (Vaddinini Dharma 4/8).

II-B: Little Hearts 95 in 27.5 overs (Jagadeesh 36, Sakthi Pitchaiyan 3/8) lost to Asiatic 98/4 in 17.2 overs (Sakthi Pitchaiyan 44).

Mani Memorial 95 in 25.2 overs lost to Royal Gems 97/3 in 12.5 overs (G. Vimalraj 35, V. Vijaya Raj 40 n.o.).

Selvaganapathy MCC 97 in 23 overs (M. Sriraman 3/26, T. Sundar 3/26) lost to Chromepet 98/3 in 15.2 overs (A. Aravindan 43 n.o.).

CHENNAI METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD NOTICE INVITING TENDER THROUGH E-TENDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING	
Date:	03 March 2026
Loan No. and Title:	Loan No:P59311-001 IND / Chennai Climate resilient Water Security and Sewerage Project (CCRWSPP) and E-Procurement Notice
Contract No. and Title:	CNT/UGSS/NCB/ADB/002/2025-26 Improvement to existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-01 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 15 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 10 & 13 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years.
Deadline for Submission of Bids:	08/04/2026 upto 15.00 Hours

1. The Government of Tamil Nadu through Government of India has applied for financing from the Asian Development Bank (ADB) toward the cost of Chennai Climate Resilient Water Security and Sewerage Project (CCRWSPP). Part of this financing will be used for payments under the Contract named above. Bidding is open to Bidders from eligible source countries of ADB.

2. The Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board ("the Employer") invites E-bids from eligible Bidders.

3. The Scope of Work: Improvement to existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-01 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 15 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 10 & 13 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years including other works within the contract scope. ("the Works").

Supplying, laying, testing and commissioning of 57.067 km of DWC / CI / HDPE gravity mains of sizes varying from 200mm dia to 700mm dia by Pipe bursting, Horizontal Directional Drilling (HDD) and open cut method of laying. Construction and upgradation of 1633 Nos of precast and cast in situ machine holes and Providing 8013 Nos of house sewer connections (HSCs) with 110mm and 160mm dia MDPE pipes. Operation and maintenance of entire collection system for a period of 5 years.

4. Open competitive bidding – National advertisement will be conducted in accordance with ADB's Single-Stage: Two-Envelope bidding procedure and is open to all Bidders from eligible countries as described in the Bidding Document.

5. Only eligible Bidders with the following key qualifications defined in the Bidding Document may participate in this bidding:

- Technical criteria specified is for at least one contract that has been satisfactorily completed within the last Five years (2020-2021 to 2024-2025).

S. No.	Qualification Criteria	Details
1	Supply, laying and commissioning of gravity sewer mains of dia minimum of 350mm of HDPE/DWC/CI/RCC for a minimum length, successfully completed in one single contract.	20 km
2	Supply, laying and commissioning of gravity sewer mains of dia minimum of 250mm of HDPE/DWC/CI/RCC for a minimum length, successfully completed using Trenchless Technology by pipe bursting / HDD in one single contract.	5 km
3	Operation & Maintenance of Sewerage Network system for a period of at least one year	1 project

Financial criteria specified are to be achieved within the last 5 years (2020–2021 to 2024–2025). (Rs. in Crores)

S. No.	Qualification Criteria	Details Rs. in Crores
4	Achieved minimum annual construction turnover calculated as total certified payments received for contracts in progress or completed.	93.61
	For Joint Venture (maximum three partners), for all partners combined (must meet the requirement)	93.61
	For any one partner	46.80
	For each partner	23.40
5	One Sewerage network construction with the component of the proposed works of the value of not less than	56.17

Details of bid security and dates of Prebid meeting, bids closing date and bids opening dates

NIT No.	Name of work	E-Bid Security (INR)	Pre bid meeting Date	E-Bid Submission closing Date	E-Bid Opening Date
1	Improvement to existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-01 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 15 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 10 & 13 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years	1.40 Cr	12/03/2026 at 11.00 Hours	08/04/2026 Upto 15.00 Hours	08/04/2026 15.30 Hours

Note : Only E-Bid security is accepted.

More details of qualification requirements are mentioned in the Bidding Documents.

6. To obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents, Bidders should contact:

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (CONTRACT & MONITORING)
CHENNAI METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD,
No.1, Pumping Station Road, Chintadripet, Chennai-02
Telephone: +91 44 28451300, Extn - 254.
E-mail: secandm@gmail.com

7. To purchase the bidding documents in English, eligible Bidders should:

- Refer to <https://tntenders.gov.in> (e-procurement portal of the Employer). The Bidding Documents will be available online on the website at [www.tntenders.gov.in](https://tntenders.gov.in) until before the deadline of bid submission.

8. Deliver your bid

- Online at <https://tntenders.gov.in> on or before the deadline date specified at 15:00 hours (IST) together with a E-Bid Security as described in the Bidding Document.
- Details of submission and opening of bids are as detailed above.

Bids will be opened promptly after the deadline for bid submission in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend.

9. The Employer/Purchaser will not be responsible for any costs or expenses incurred by Bidders in connection with the preparation or submission/delivery of bids.

CE (O&M)-II/SE (C&M) i/c. (Contracts & Monitoring)

DIPR/1573/TENDER/2026

CHENNAI METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD NOTICE INVITING TENDER THROUGH E-TENDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING	
Date:	03 March 2026
Loan No. and Title:	Loan No:P59311-001 IND/Chennai Climate resilient Water Security and Sewerage Project (CCRWSPP) and E-Procurement Notice
Contract No. and Title:	CNT/UGSS/NCB/ADB/004/2025-26 Improvement to Existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-03 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 7 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 9 & 10 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years.
Deadline for Submission of Bids:	08/04/2026 Up to 15.00 Hours

1. The Government of Tamil Nadu through Government of India has applied for financing from the Asian Development Bank (ADB) toward the cost of Chennai Climate Resilient Water Security and Sewerage Project (CCRWSPP). Part of this financing will be used for payments under the Contract named above. Bidding is open to Bidders from eligible source countries of ADB.

2. The Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board ("the Employer") invites E-bids from eligible Bidders.

3. The Scope of Work: Improvement to existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-03 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 7 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 9 & 10 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years. Including other works within the contract scope. ("the Works").

Supplying, laying, testing and commissioning of 59.425 km of DWC / CI / HDPE gravity mains of sizes varying from 200mm dia to 700mm dia by Pipe bursting, Horizontal Directional Drilling (HDD) and open cut method of laying. Construction and upgradation of 1666 Nos of precast and cast in situ machine holes and Providing 7928 Nos of house sewer connections (HSCs) with 110mm and 160mm dia MDPE pipes. Operation and maintenance of entire collection system for a period of 5 years.

4. Open competitive bidding – National advertisement will be conducted in accordance with ADB's Single-Stage: Two-Envelope bidding procedure and is open to all Bidders from eligible countries as described in the Bidding Document.

5. Only eligible Bidders with the following key qualifications defined in the Bidding Document may participate in this bidding:

- Technical criteria specified is for at least one contract that has been satisfactorily completed within the last Five years (2020-2021 to 2024-2025).

S. No.	Qualification Criteria	Details
1.	Supply, laying and commissioning of gravity sewer mains of dia minimum of 350mm of HDPE/DWC/CI/RCC for a minimum length, successfully completed in one single contract.	20 km
2.	Supply, laying and commissioning of gravity sewer mains of dia minimum of 200mm of HDPE/DWC/CI/RCC for a minimum length, successfully completed using Trenchless Technology by pipe bursting / HDD in one single contract.	5.40 km
3.	Operation & Maintenance of Sewerage Network system for a period of at least one year	1 project

Financial criteria specified are to be achieved within the last 5 years (2020–2021 to 2024–2025). (Rs. in Crores)

S. No.	Qualification Criteria	Details (Rs. in Crores)
4.	Achieved minimum annual construction turnover calculated as total certified payments received for contracts in progress or completed.	89.30
	For Joint Venture (maximum three partners), for all partners combined (must meet the requirement)	89.30
	For any one partner	44.65
	For each partner	22.32
5.	One Sewerage network construction with the component of the proposed works of the value of not less than	53.57

Details of bid security and dates of Prebid meeting, bids closing date and bids opening dates

NIT No.	Name of work	E-Bid Security (INR)	Pre bid meeting Date	E-Bid Submission closing Date	E-Bid Opening Date
1	Improvement to existing sewerage system under Nesapakkam STP catchment area – SW-03 - Rehabilitation and enlargement of existing collection system with HSCs under 7 Nos of LS/SPS in Area 9 & 10 and Operation & maintenance of entire collection system for 5 years.	1.34 Cr	12/03/2026 at 11.00 Hours	08/04/2026 Upto 15.00 Hours	08/04/2026 15.30 Hours

Note: Only E-Bid security is accepted.

More details of qualification requirements are mentioned in the Bidding Documents.

6. To obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents, Bidders should contact:

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (CONTRACT & MONITORING)
CHENNAI METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD,
No.1, Pumping Station Road, Chintadripet, Chennai-02
Telephone: +91 44 28451300, Extn:254
E-mail: secandm@gmail.com

7. To purchase the bidding documents in English, eligible Bidders should:

- Refer to <https://tntenders.gov.in> (e-procurement portal of the Employer). The Bidding Documents will be available online on the website at [www.tntenders.gov.in](https://tntenders.gov.in) until before the deadline of bid submission.

8. Deliver your bid

- Online at <https://tntenders.gov.in> on or before the deadline date specified at 15:00 hours (IST) together with a E-Bid Security as described in the Bidding Document.
- Details of submission and opening of bids are as detailed above.

Bids will be opened promptly after the deadline for bid submission in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend.

9. The Employer/Purchaser will not be responsible for any costs or expenses incurred by Bidders in connection with the preparation or submission/delivery of bids.

CE (O&M)-II/SE (C&M) i/c. (Contracts & Monitoring)

DIPR/1574/TENDER/2026

**KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD**
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar
Bengaluru - 560 009. Phone No. 080-22265383, website: www.kiadb.in
IADB/ENGG/ETND-EP-91/2286/2025-26 **Date: 04.03.2026**

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item Rate Tender under two cover bid system is invited for the works mentioned below as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, state of the art technology, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the work of :
Name of the Work : Formation of 15m wide road, 18m wide road, 24m wide road, 30m wide road & 45m wide road, construction of RCC Side Drain, Construction of spur culvert & Construction of box culvert at Dobaspet 5th Phase Industrial Area, Nelamangala Taluk, Bengaluru Rural District.
The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **07.04.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**
Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>.
Sd/-
Chief Engineer-1, KIADB Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/6010/ZEN/2025-26



வெல்வோம்
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5 ஆண்டுகளில் நிறைவேற்றப்பட்ட திட்டங்கள்



கலைஞர் கனவு இல்லம்

கிராமப்புற மக்களின் வீட்டுக் கனவு
நனவாகியது

- 2 இலட்சம் வீடுகளுக்கு அனுமதி
- 1.79 இலட்சம் வீடுகள் கட்டப்பட்டுள்ளன
- மேலும் 1 இலட்சம் வீடுகள் கட்ட அனுமதி

2016-21	2021-26
1,00,000	1,79,850



**இலங்கைத் தமிழர்களுக்கு
நிரந்தர வீடு**

10,045 வீடுகள் கட்ட ரூ. 589 கோடி
நிதி ஒதுக்கீடு செய்யப்பட்டு, 7,469 வீடுகள்
கட்டும்பணி நிறைவு



அடுக்குமாடிக் குடியிருப்புத் திட்டம்

- 58,211 வீடுகள் ரூ. 8,384 கோடியில்
கட்டி முடிக்கப்பட்டன
- 53,467 வீடுகள் கட்டுமானப் பணிகள்
நடைபெற்று வருகின்றன

2016-21	2021-26
27,688	58,211



தொல்குடி திட்டம்

7,674 பழங்குடியினர் வீடுகளின் கட்டுமானப்
பணிகள் ரூ. 221 கோடி மதிப்பில் நிறைவு



**தமிழ்நாடு நகர்ப்புற வாழ்விட
மேம்பாட்டு வாரியம்**

தாமாக வீடு கட்டும் திட்டம்
2.63 இலட்சம் வீடுகள்
ரூ. 3,058 கோடியில் கட்டி முடிக்கப்பட்டன

2016-21	2021-26
1,40,250	2,63,941



**கிராமப்புற வீடுகள் முழுமையாக
புதுப்பிப்பு**

1,14,470 வீடுகள் ரூ. 975 கோடியில் புதுப்பிப்பு



வீட்டுமனைப் பட்டாக்கள்

கடந்த 5 ஆண்டுகளில் 23.56 இலட்சம்
நபர்களுக்கு வீட்டுமனைப் பட்டாக்கள்
வழங்கப்பட்டுள்ளன

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எளிமை ஆளுமை



Online Approval

**வீடு கட்ட திட்ட அனுமதிமுறை
எளிமையாக்கம்**

ஆன்லைனில் ஒற்றைச் சாளர முறை
திட்டத்தின் கீழ் 24,446 மனைப்பிரிவு
விண்ணப்பங்களும், 9,002 கட்டிட
விண்ணப்பங்களுக்கு எளிதில் அனுமதி

சுயசான்றிதழ் திட்டத்தின் கீழ்
3,500 சதுர அடி வரையிலான கட்டிட அனுமதி
இதுவரை 1.7 இலட்சத்திற்கும் மேற்பட்டவர்கள்
எளிதில் அனுமதி பெற்றுள்ளனர்



தமிழ்நாட்டின் வளர்ச்சிப் பயணத்தில் ஒருவரையும் பின்தங்க விடமாட்டோம்!



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FAIRS & FESTIVALS

TRADITIONAL CUSTOMS AND ANCIENT CULTURES OF TAMIL NADU

Tamils have traditionally celebrated festivals to mark the changing seasons, and these celebrations were not confined to spring alone. Even the summer months were filled with festivals that reflected the rich cultural heritage and customs of the people. Deeply rooted in ancient customs and traditions, many of these festivals gradually assumed religious overtones.

The coffee-table book *Fairs and Festivals of Tamil Nadu*, vividly captures the history and spirit of these celebrations through eye-catching photographs and engaging write-ups. While urbanisation has diminished the charm of some festivals, their spirit continues to endure. The book inspires readers to travel across the State and experience these vibrant festivals firsthand.



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Stalin releases policies for shipbuilding, agroforestry

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday released the Tamil Nadu Shipbuilding Policy 2026 and the Tamil Nadu Agroforestry Policy 2026. The shipbuilding policy looks to strengthen the State's maritime manufacturing ecosystem. It offers targeted incentives to attract shipbuilding and ship-repair companies, positioning Tamil Nadu as a competitive hub in India's growing blue economy.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 2

Fish eye



Visual treat: Visitors at the newly inaugurated fish aquarium on the Tirunelveli collectorate premises. A. SHAIKMOHIDEEN

CBI begins probe into Pondy counterfeit drugs case

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered two cases against suspects involved in the sensational counterfeit drugs sale case in Puducherry.

Acting on a request made by the Government of Puducherry, the CBI's Anti Corruption Unit, Delhi, registered the cases against three suspects on charges of illegal drug manufacturing, storage, distribution and related offences detected at Mettupalayam and Sedara-

CB-CID probe had indicated possible inter-State links and organised criminal networks

pet areas of the Union Territory of Puducherry.

In simultaneous searches conducted on suspected premises between September 1 and December 12, 2025, the Department of Drugs Control, Puducherry, found several drug manufacturing units functioning in violation of the provisions of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.

The premises were sealed and large quantities of finished pharmaceutical products, raw materials, machinery and equipment were seized.

Samples drawn from the seizures were sent to the Central Drugs Testing Laboratory, Chennai, for a detailed analysis regarding quality, safety and statutory compliance.

A case was registered by the local police which was later transferred to the Crime Branch Criminal Investigation Department for further investigation.

In a letter to CBI Director, the Special Home Se-

cretary, Puducherry, said the CB-CID conducted extensive investigation leading to multiple arrests and seizure of incriminating materials.

The investigations conducted so far revealed possible inter-State ramifications, complex supply chains, financial transactions, and involvement of multiple persons operating across different States, indicating the presence of organised criminal networks engaged in illegal drug manufacturing and distribution.

The probe had also indicated the likelihood of ille-

gal financial flows and organised activities having potential implications for public health, economic security, and national interest.

Though the CB-CID had conducted an effective investigation so far, it was felt further investigation in the matter might require specialised multi-disciplinary expertise, inter-State coordination, financial investigation capability, and possible international liaison capabilities of the CBI.

Hence, the Puducherry administration had decided to transfer the case to the CBI, the letter said.

U.K. museum returns 16th century bronze statue to Indian govt.

The Thirumangai Alvar statue belongs to Sundararaja Perumal Temple in Thanjavur district; the handover follows a detailed provenance research

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

The Ashmolean Museum in Oxford, England, has returned a 16th century bronze statue of Saint Thirumangai Alvar to the Government of India, following a detailed provenance research and liaison with Indian authorities.

The handover was marked at a ceremony at the High Commission of India in London on Tuesday. Ashmolean director Xa Sturgis and professor Mallika Kumbura Landrus, head of the museum's Department of Eastern Art, were present.

In a statement, Mr. Sturgis said, "The Ashmolean is pleased to see this important object returned to India, and we are grateful to the Indian authorities and scholars who have helped establish its provenance. The Museum and the University of Oxford are committed to ethical collection practices and continued research into our collections, and their history."

A High Commission spokesperson thanked the museum for its decision to return the bronze icon to its



The statue was handed over to the High Commission of India in London. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

of an icon of faith with its intended shrine, restoring memory, and enabling cultural continuity".

Museum got it in 1967
The Ashmolean acquired the statue in 1967. According to the Sotheby's catalogue, the bronze was sold by private collector J.R. Belmont (1886-1981), though no information is available on how it entered his collection. In November 2019, an independent French scholar alerted the museum to research linking the bronze to a 1957 photograph taken at the Shri Sundararaja Perumal Temple. The image was in the archives of the Institut Français de Pondichéry and the École française d'Extrême-Orient (IFP-EFEO). The scholar identified the bronze as one of several objects in collections in Europe and the United States recorded in the archives.

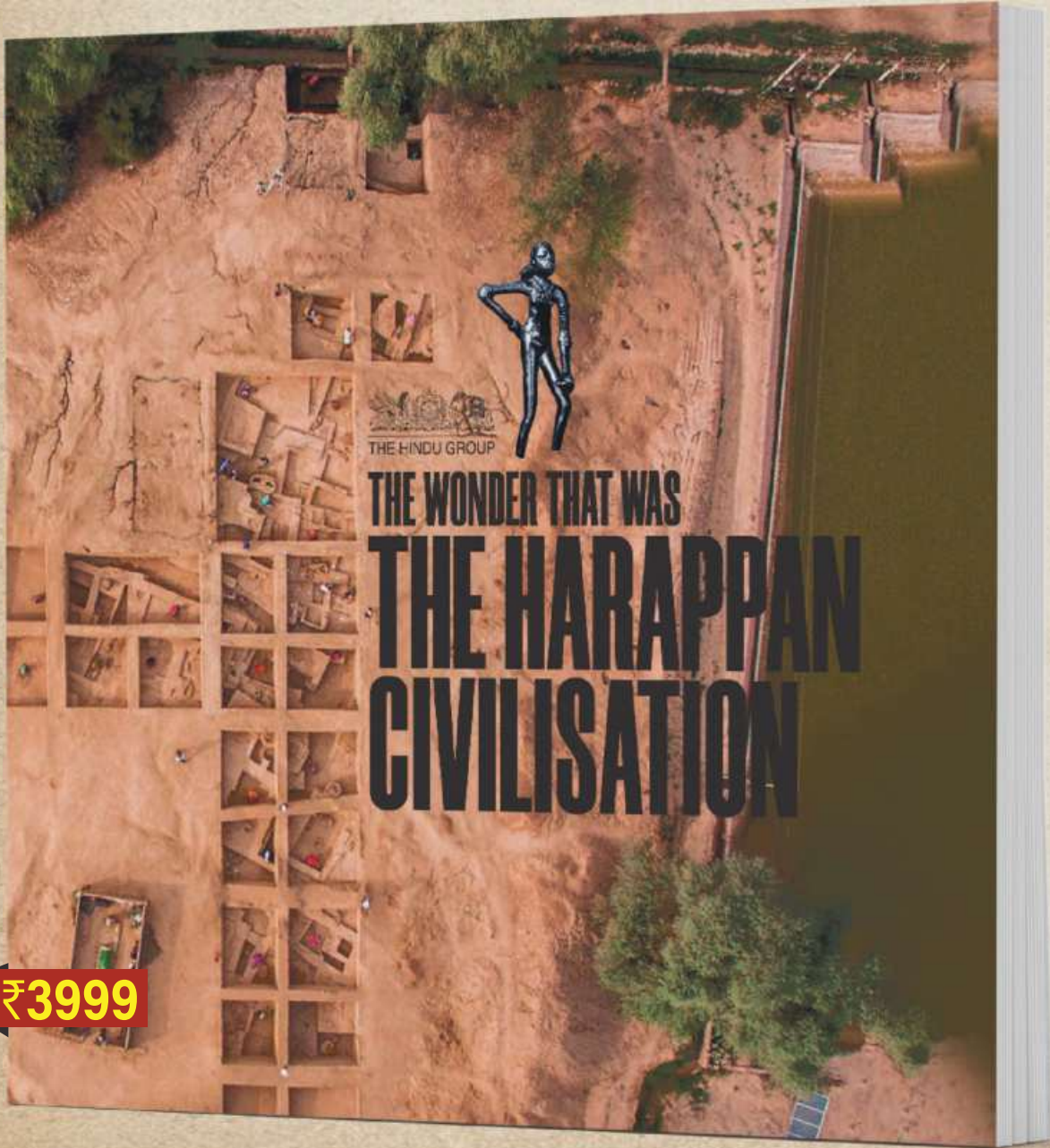
On February 11, 2020, a temple executive officer filed a police report noting that a modern replica had replaced the original bronze. The Indian High Commissioner then made a formal claim for the return of the bronze statue on March 3, 2020.

original place of worship - the Sundararaja Perumal temple in Thanjavur district in Tamil Nadu. The spokesperson described the move as "not merely the restoration of an object of art, but the reunification

NEW
ARRIVAL

A SPECIAL PUBLICATION FROM THE HINDU GROUP

The Hindu marks the centenary of the announcement of the discovery of the Indus Civilisation with a new edition of the book 'The Wonder that was the Harappan Civilisation'. The book has a bonanza of photographs and 48 extra pages, featuring interviews with Director General, Archaeological Survey of India, Y S Rawat, scholars R S Bisht and Asko Parpola. There are new stories on the excavations at Karanpura and Padka Bet, both Harappan sites in India. A treasure to own.



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INBRIEF



MNM holds talks with DMK, seeks seats in metro cities

Makkal Needhi Maiam, founded by actor Kamal Haasan, is learnt to have presented a wishlist of over 10 Assembly seats during its meeting with the DMK's seat sharing committee at Anna Arivalayam on Wednesday. Sources in the MNM said their demands were received cordially and hoped they would be allotted a respectable number of seats. "We have presented a list of constituencies, mostly in metro cities. We hope they respond favourably," a party functionary said. Despite joining the DMK alliance in 2024, the party did not contest the Lok Sabha election, but Mr. Haasan was elected to the Rajya Sabha.

Constantine Ravindran, Tiruchi Siva are DMK's RS candidates

DMK on Wednesday evening announced its candidates for the biennial election to Rajya Sabha. Three time MP Tiruchi N. Siva and a key spokesperson Constantine Ravindran are the candidates. It is a record of sorts for Mr. Siva, who will be entering the Rajya Sabha for the fifth time. The DMK has allotted one seat each to the Congress and the DMKD. Thursday is the last date for filing of nominations for the biennial polls.

Chief Minister releases shipbuilding and agroforestry policies, launches projects

Stalin lays the foundation for the first phase of works to develop the Guindy Eco Park, which will be developed at a cost of ₹37.85 crore with features such as herbal gardens and an aviary; he also inaugurates a 30-metre Super Tree Tower at Kalaingar Centenary Park in Chennai built at ₹11.84 crore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday released the Tamil Nadu Shipbuilding Policy 2026 and the Tamil Nadu Agroforestry Policy 2026. He also inaugurated, through video conference from the Secretariat in Chennai, completed projects and laid the foundation stone for new infrastructure initiatives of various departments.

The shipbuilding policy looks to strengthen the State's maritime manufacturing ecosystem. The policy offers targeted incentives to attract shipbuilding and ship-repair companies, positioning Tamil Nadu as a competitive hub in India's growing blue economy. The policy seeks to develop shipbuilding clusters that bring together design, fabrication, repair, research and development, and training.

Shipyards manufacturing large ocean-going vessels catering to overseas as

well as coastal trade; medium size specialised vessels; defence and naval crafts and coast guard vessels; submarines and any kind of underwater equipment used for transportation; and mechanised fishing boats (excluding trawlers and fiberglass or FRP boats), will be eligible for incentives under the policy. And any firm involved in the activity of ship maintenance, repair and recycling, excluding recycled steel processing and similar activities, also qualify.

The State government will create an special purpose vehicle (SPV) with separate legal existence under SIPCOT. An agency nominated by the Centre will be invited as a major stakeholder.

The SPV will facilitate and enable establishment of shipyards in the identified clusters. On the incentives front, the State has come out with a structured package of assistance – the State government directly or through an identified government agency may



Chief Minister M.K. Stalin releasing the agroforestry policy at the Secretariat in Chennai on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

become a minority equity stakeholder in the proposed facility. Shipyards can submit business proposals to an identified entity as notified in the implementation guidelines seeking equity investment.

Shipyards investing a minimum of ₹100 crore for undertaking green initiatives and implementing green technologies in the ship or any activity detailed as per the implementation guidelines as a green initiative will be eligible for a 50% subsidy, subject to a limit of 2% of the total project cost or ₹50 crore per

project – whichever is lower – as a one-time disbursement post completion of the committed investment. The policy places a strong emphasis on sustainability, environmental, social, and governance compliance, and Industry 4.0 practices, ensuring that innovation, environmental responsibility, and advanced technology are at the core of the State's shipbuilding growth.

Mr. Stalin laid the foundation stone for the first phase of works to develop the Guindy Eco Park being carried out by the Depart-

ment of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare. The park will be developed at an estimated cost of ₹37.85 crore with various features including theme gardens, a children's play area, bird habitat islands, herbal gardens, an aviary habitat centre, lawns, viewing decks and gazebos. He also inaugurated a 30-metre-high Super Tree Tower at the Kalaingar Centenary Park built at a cost of ₹11.84 crore with nine levels.

Under the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department, Mr. Stalin inaugurated six completed projects worth ₹1,404.27 crore undertaken by the Tamil Nadu Water Supply and Drainage (TWAD) Board, 16 completed projects worth ₹529.54 crore by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB), 93 completed projects worth ₹349.76 crore by the Directorate of Municipal Administration, 76 completed projects worth ₹389.93 crore by the Directorate of Town Plan-

MoU for tyre plant

In the presence of the Chief Minister, a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed between the Department of Industries and Investment Promotion and the MRF to set up a new tyre manufacturing plant at the SIPCOT Iluppai Industrial Park in Sivaganga district. The project involves an investment commitment of ₹5,300 crore and is expected to generate 1,000 jobs.

DMK, AIADMK colluding to prevent my rise to power, alleges TVK chief

The Hindu Bureau
THANJAVUR

In a veiled attack on the Dravidian majors, Tamila-ga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) founder and actor Vijay on Wednesday accused the DMK and AIADMK of having a secret understanding to capture power alternately and of conspiring to thwart him from coming to power. Listing TVK's poll promises, Mr. Vijay assured a waiver of cooperative crop loans for farmers with landholdings of up to five acres and promised that educational expenses of the wards of farmers owning up to two acres of land and of landless labourers would be borne by the government.

Mr. Vijay, while addressing a party functionaries' meet at Sengipatti near Thanjavur, said: "Politics is not about 'collection'; it requires working for the people. We have come into politics to serve the peo-



TVK president Vijay addressing supporters near Sengipatti in Thanjavur on Wednesday.

Our enemies know this well. That is why there are so many conspiracies around us. Prominent among them is a deal between them [the DMK and AIADMK] to prevent anybody else from coming to power."

'Cheating the people'

Without explicitly naming the two parties, he said they had a deal to ensure that one of them remained in power so as "to keep cheating the people," though outwardly, they seemed to be at odds with

one another. "They have realised their plan will not work due to my entry into politics. So, one of them is trying to impose 'SOP after SOP' (standard operating procedure, an apparent reference to the conditions imposed on his political meetings), while the other is indulging in mudslinging," he alleged.

"Allegations after allegations have been made, starting from Karur [stamped] to the release of [the film] *Jananayagan*. At least in the *Jananayagan* release issue, many had voiced their support - including Chief Minister [M.K.] Stalin, though in a non-committal way. But whatever it is, I thank him and the others for that," he said.

Mr. Vijay, however, came down heavily on the DMK government, terming it "a fraudulent government" and not a model one, as claimed by the party. He cited some of the 2021 poll promises of the

DMK and accused the party of failing to implement them. It had even promised to abolish the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test, knowing well that it would not be able to fulfil it, he alleged.

"Claims such as the 'DMK is the protector of Tamil Nadu and DMK is the saviour of minorities' will not work this time," he claimed.

The Assembly election was not a mere election but an "emotion" for him and the people of Tamil Nadu. Mr. Stalin's claims that he would return to power – a task that could not be achieved even by his father and former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi – would never come true, Mr. Vijay said.

If voted to power, the TVK will not implement any project against the wishes of farmers, even if there is pressure from the Union government, he said.

DMK-Congress deal: the leaders who were pivotal in breaking the stalemate

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

If the DMK and Congress on Wednesday night managed to move past a tense phase in their seat-sharing negotiations, it is thanks to the sustained efforts of Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge, former Union Minister P. Chidambaram, DMK Parliamentary Party leader Kanimozhi, and Congress MP Karti P. Chidambaram.

Happy over the conclusion of the deal, a senior DMK leader acknowledged their roles.

"The talks had reached a stalemate after both parties adopted firm positions on the number of seats to be allotted. Progress was seen only after the Congress high command deputed Mr. Chidambaram to negotiate independently of the party's seat-sharing committee. Mr. Kharge was in constant touch with Ms. Kanimozhi and was keen



Mallikarjun Kharge



P. Chidambaram



Kanimozhi

on ensuring the Congress remained within the DMK-led alliance," the DMK leader told *The Hindu*.

Congress leader Sonia Gandhi was also said to be in favour of continuing the partnership.

When Mr. Chidambaram met Chief Minister and DMK president M.K. Stalin, he reportedly explained the DMK's compulsions, particularly the need to accommodate smaller allies within the DMK-led front. Mr. Stalin is said to have outlined the DMK's strengthened position over the past five

years, the Statewide conferences conducted across Tamil Nadu, protests organised against policies of the BJP-led Union government, and the recent demonstrations against the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

Still, Mr. Stalin increased the number of Assembly seats to 27, taking into consideration the stature of Mr. Chidambaram. Even then, the two parties could not reach an agreement.

Mr. Stalin added one more seat after Mr. Kharge personally spoke to him

over the phone on Wednesday morning.

The Chief Minister is said to have reminded Mr. Kharge that the DMK had consistently supported the Congress and its Prime Ministerial candidates in the past, and questioned how the Congress could refrain from standing by the DMK at this juncture.

"We are happy that we reached the agreement and our alliance continues. Our leader also proved accommodative," a DMK source said, expressing satisfaction over the outcome.

Thirupparankundram row: Justice Swaminathan grants time to reply to suggestion

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Board of Trustees of the Subramaniya Swamy Temple in Thirupparankundram told the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court on Wednesday that the court's suggestion that respect could be shown to its earlier order allowing the *Karthigai Deepam* to be lit on the newly identified *deepathoon* (stone pillar) atop Thirupparankundram hill by permitting five persons to go to the lower peak and offer symbolic prayers for 15 minutes, needs to be deliberated.

Justice G.R. Swaminathan was told his suggestion needs to be deliberated and a careful decision has to be taken after consulting the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments



The judge posted the contempt petitions related to the *Karthigai Deepam* row for hearing on March 18. R. ASHOK

Department. The court dispensed with the appearance of the Board of Trustees.

Justice Swaminathan posted the contempt petitions related to the *Karthigai Deepam* row for hearing on March 18. The judge on Monday had suggested that respect could be

shown to the court's earlier order allowing the *Karthigai Deepam* to be lit on the *deepathoon* (stone pillar) atop the Thirupparankundram hill by permitting five persons named by the court to go to the lower peak where the pillar is and offer symbolic prayers for 15 minutes. The judge had said this was a suggestion and not a direction.

The judge made the suggestion after Madurai Collector K.J. Praveen Kumar, in an additional affidavit, tendered an unconditional apology.

The Collector told the court the prohibitory order under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, was issued on the basis of the ground situation at Thirupparankundram and so as to maintain law and order.

Palaniswami meets AIADMK's district secretaries in Chennai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Wednesday held consultations with district secretaries of his party as part of the preparation for the Assembly election.

The consultations took place a few days after Mr. Palaniswami's meeting with Union Minister for Home Affairs Amit Shah in New Delhi.

Asked about the AIADMK's seat-sharing arrangement with the BJP, the party's organisation secretary and former Minister D. Jayakumar told reporters that this was a matter handled by some others in the party, as he was a part of the poll manifesto committee.

Mr. Jayakumar advised the Tamilaga Vettri Kazha-

gam (TVK) founder Vijay to begin holding press conferences and cautioned him not to make "derisive comments" about the AIADMK.

Party's RS candidate

The AIADMK on Wednesday announced the renomination of its senior leader, M. Thambi Durai, for the lone Rajya Sabha seat that it would contest. This was announced by Mr. Palaniswami in a press release.

In another release, Mr. Palaniswami said another seat of the Upper House had been allotted to the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK).

Meanwhile, former party functionary of the AIADMK, Va. Pugazhendhi, who carried on legal battles against the party, announced the formation of the Puratchi Anna DMK in New Delhi.

Investigation finds caste motive behind attack in Nanguneri

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUNELVELI

The recent double murder in Nanguneri, which was initially believed to be an attack unleashed by a group of intoxicated youth without provocation, has been revealed to be an assault orchestrated by members of a dominant intermediate caste to silence youth from other communities.

During their investigation, the police found that a group of Paraiyar community youth from Indra Colony in Perumpaththu had recently put up posters glorifying 'Manalmedu' Shankar, a lorry driver from the Delta region who was killed in an encounter with the police in February 2007.

He had faced several murder, abduction, and drug-smuggling charges. When 'Manalmedu' Shan-

kar attacked the police and tried to escape custody when he was being escorted to Madurai Central Prison from the court, he was shot dead in self-defence, the police had then claimed.

As these posters of 'Manalmedu' Shankar put up around Nanguneri and along the highways to commemorate his death anniversary reportedly angered members of an intermediate caste living in a few hamlets around Nanguneri, they attacked some people who were standing at a roadside teashop at Indra Colony near Perumpaththu on Monday night.

Of the seven suspects arrested in connection with the incident, two – Subbaiah alias Subhash, 19, and Kalyani, 19 – have been cited as accused in an earlier attack case. The duo was also named as accused in a sexual harass-

ment case. Despite heavy police presence in and around Perumpaththu effectively preventing any further untoward incidents, an eerie silence prevails in Nanguneri after the attack with a caste overtone.

The family of John, a Paraiyar community man murdered in the attack, refused to receive his body. When VCK chief Thol. Thirumavalavan spoke to John's family during a video call on Tuesday, they made it clear that they would accept the body only after due action was taken against the attackers.

Speaker meets victims

Speaker M. Appavu, who, along with District Collector R. Sukumar, visited the injured at the Tirunelveli Medical College Hospital on Tuesday, assured them of medical treatment to expedite their recovery.

INBRIEF



Five from Bengaluru killed in Chittoor road accident

Five residents of Bengaluru were killed in a road accident near Gangavaram Cross, on the Chittoor-Bengaluru NH on Wednesday. They were en route the Venkateswara Temple in Tirumala, police said. The deceased – three women and two men – were identified as Mohan Das (71), Nagaraja Rao (61), Kusuma (61), Jayanthi (59) and Pooja (33). Their car reportedly rammed a stationary lorry on the highway, killing them all on the spot. A case has been registered.

HC sets aside order allowing home food for jailed actor

Stating that home-cooked food can be given to undertrials only on medical advice for health reasons and not on the basis of a mere request, the High Court of Karnataka on Wednesday set aside a trial court's order allowing home-cooked food once a week to actor Darshan, his friend Pavithra Gowda, and other accused persons, arrested in connection with the Renukaswamy murder case, and lodged in the Parappana Agrahara Central Prison in Bengaluru.

ED questions Sabarimala Tantri in gold theft case

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) on Wednesday questioned Sabarimala Tantri (chief priest) Kandararu Rajeevaru in connection with the gold theft case. The questioning lasted for around four hours. The ED is learnt to have questioned him about his association with Unnikrishnan Potti, the prime accused in the case. The ED was also looking at the Kerala High Court appointed SIT's alleged findings related to the Tantri's financial transactions.

Karnataka HC orders release of foreigners over lapses

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Stating that the right guaranteed under Article 22(1) of the Constitution, against the arrest of a person without being informed about the grounds of arrest, extends even to foreign nationals, the High Court of Karnataka has ordered the release of two Nigerian nationals as the grounds for their arrest were contrary to Supreme Court's guidelines. However, the court directed the authorities to deport them after they were released, as they were overstaying in India for over a decade without a visa.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna passed the order while allowing the petition filed by the two foreign nationals who had challenged the legality of their arrest by the Bengaluru City Police in 2024. They were arrested on the charges of possessing narcotic substances and violation of the Foreigners Act. "The Constitutional protection under Article 22 extends to all persons within the territory of India, including foreign nationals as it is not citizen-centric but person-centric," the court observed.

Deportation The court said that the moment the petitioners are set at liberty, they must be handed over to the Foreigners Regional Registration Office for further action. The court directed the State government to constitute screening committees on overstaying foreign nationals and submit a report within four months.

From selfies in Vizag to a watery grave off Sri Lanka

The U.S. torpedo attack on an Iranian warship and its sinking has triggered shock and disbelief across the A.P. coastal city from where the navy personnel had sailed out in late February



Turn of events: Naval personnel from Iran stand for a photo shoot on the glass bridge at Kailasagiri during their tour of Visakhapatnam (left); and an injured Iranian sailor at the Karapitiya hospital in Galle, Sri Lanka, on Wednesday. V. RAJU/AFP



Harish Gilai
VISAKHAPATNAM

Reports of a United States submarine torpedoing and sinking an Iranian warship in the Indian Ocean off the coast of Sri Lanka have left residents of Visakhapatnam stunned. The development triggered disbelief across the coastal city, particularly because personnel from the Iranian Navy had visited the "City of Destiny" barely two weeks ago to participate in the International Fleet Review 2026 (IFR) and MILAN 2026.

Towards home After the closing ceremony of MILAN in the last week of February, the Iranian ship had sailed out of Visakhapatnam. Apart from participating in the IFR and the MILAN city parade, the officers and sailors of the reportedly sunk vessel, IRIS Dena, had left a lasting impression on the citizens.

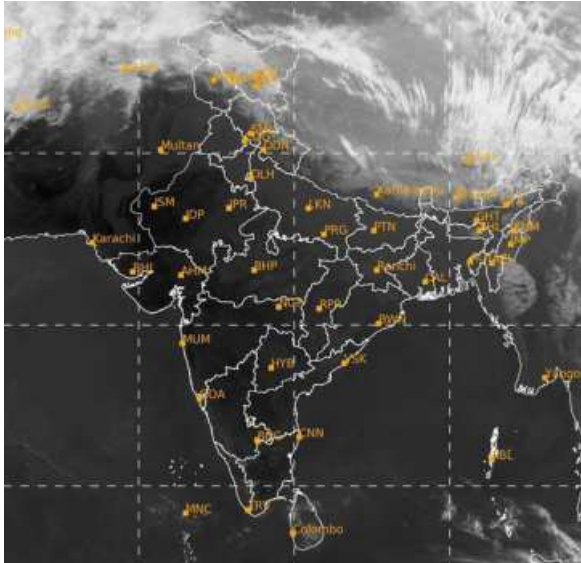
They had visited several tourist spots, including the popular Kailasagiri. "They clicked numerous selfies and photographs with locals at the park, especially on the glass skywalk bridge," recalled a city resident. The personnel had also visited shopping malls, purchasing souvenirs and artefacts to take back home. "Little did they know that they might meet a watery grave miles away from their homeland," he said. Expressing anguish, a former senior Indian naval officer remarked that the ship had been on a goodwill mission and was on its way back home. "It is true that a carrier battle group is typically protected by submarines positioned miles apart, supported by a fleet of ships and airborne assets such as the P-8I aircraft, which is capable of launching anti-ship missiles and torpedoes. The U.S. Navy should have exercised

some restraint," he said. More importantly, he noted, both the United States and Iran had participated in the IFR and MILAN exercises, with officers from the two nations staying under the same roof in city hotels. He added that the attack might have occurred during the "middle watch" – between midnight and 4 a.m. – considered one of the most vulnerable phases for any ship navigating troubled waters. **Memorable moments** During their visit, the Iranian Navy personnel spent memorable moments exploring the coastal city. They toured prominent tourist destinations, taking in Visakhapatnam's scenic beauty and warm hospitality. The delegation visited Kailasagiri, Tenneti Park, and VMRDA Park. The glass bridge experience, in particular, left them awestruck by the sweeping coastline.

The Iranian contingent had actively participated in the International City Parade organised as part of MILAN 2026 at Beach Road on February 20. The parade drew enthusiastic crowds, with many residents seizing the opportunity to click selfies with naval personnel from Iran and other participating nations during the concluding ceremony. For several locals, news of the reported naval strike has come as a profound shock. S. Pawan, a young resident who had photographed Iranian Navy personnel during the City Parade, expressed disbelief over the reports. "It is truly shocking to hear this news. Just days ago, I clicked pictures with Iranian Navy officers during the parade on Beach Road. They were friendly and cheerful. It is hard to believe that something like this has happened so soon," he posted on his X account.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.45 HRS)

Forecast for Thursday: Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Gujarat, north Konkan and coastal Andhra Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		31.7	19.0	Kozhikode		35.6	25.6
Ahmedabad		38.6	20.0	Kurnool		38.5	23.2
Aizawl		29.5	12.1	Lucknow		30.5	15.2
Allahabad		32.2	14.2	Madurai		37.0	20.1
Bengaluru		32.4	19.8	Mangaluru		33.4	22.6
Bhopal		34.4	14.6	Mumbai		38.7	23.8
Bhubaneswar		36.8	19.2	Mysuru		33.4	16.8
Chandigarh		31.4	13.8	New Delhi		33.2	15.7
Chennai		34.1	22.2	Patna		31.5	18.4
Coimbatore		34.4	20.6	Port Blair		31.5	22.2
Dehradun		31.2	13.6	Puducherry		31.6	21.7
Gangtok		19.2	11.1	Pune		37.7	20.8
Goa		32.9	24.7	Raipur		37.0	20.3
Guwahati		32.1	16.2	Ranchi		30.0	13.0
Hubballi		31.4	13.8	Shillong		21.5	10.0
Hyderabad		35.7	20.5	Shimla		27.2	13.4
Imphal		27.9	10.0	Srinagar		20.5	4.2
Jaipur		35.2	20.2	Thiruvananthapuram		33.7	22.0
Kochi		31.4	26.0	Tiruchi		35.7	21.0
Kohima		21.7	11.0	Vijayawada		35.4	22.4
Kolkata		33.2	18.4	Visakhapatnam		31.6	23.8

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Cuttack, Odisha recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 308 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Bhilai, Chhattisgarh recorded a healthy AQI score of 33
Ahmedabad		79	102	30	101	130	
Bengaluru		14	38	21	172	122	
Chennai		5	7	33	83	108	
Delhi		44	26	28	221	318	
Hyderabad		5	9	56	112	125	
Kolkata		3	28	45	156	126	
Lucknow		6	37	46	156	165	
Mumbai		23	79	47	109	105	
Pune		6	61	22	208	157	
Visakhapatnam		20	85	18	122	122	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Celebrating valour



Sikh devotees take out a procession from Gowliguda to mark Hola Mohalla, a festival founded by Guru Gobind Singh to celebrate Sikh valour, unity and martial tradition, in Hyderabad on Wednesday. SIDDHANT THAKUR

Senior CPI(M) leader signals break with party after 63 years

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader and former Minister G. Sudhakaran on Wednesday indicated a break with the party he served for 63 years. In a Facebook post, Mr. Sudhakaran said he had not applied for membership scrutiny (an annual intra-party exercise) because he felt that the party's State and district (Alappuzha) leadership had "spurned and ridiculed him."

Mr. Sudhakaran's scathing attack on the party came on a day the CPI(M)

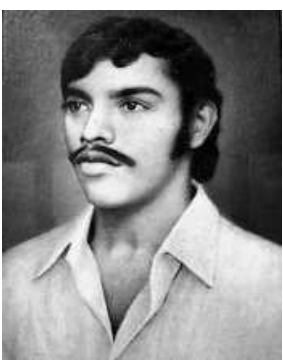
State Secretariat met in Thiruvananthapuram to vet the list of prospective candidates for the 2026 Kerala Assembly election. He alleged that State secretary M.V. Govindan had "dismissively mocked him" at a press conference, drawing derisive laughter from journalists. He said the CPI(M)'s district leadership had "walked the extra mile to wilfully isolate him" by not inviting him to public functions. Meanwhile, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby told reporters that Mr. Sudhakaran's Facebook post was "news" to him.

50 years on, Rajan's death still shrouded in mystery

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

Fifty years after college student P. Rajan's custodial death during the Emergency, his death and disappearance of his mortal remains is still a mystery. Rajan was a student of the Regional Engineering College, Kozhikode, when he, along with another student was taken into custody, on suspicion that they maintained close links with Naxalites, who allegedly attacked the Kayanna police station, Kozhikode, on February 28, 1976. On a habeas corpus petition filed by his father T.V. Eachara Varier, the Kerala High Court had concluded that Rajan was taken into custody on March 1, 1976,

from the college and was later seen in police custody at a tourist bungalow in Kozhikode. His arrest and disappearance led to widespread protests against 'police excesses' in Kerala after the Emergency period. K. Karunakaran, who became the Chief Minister in the election held after the Emergency, had to step down following a stricture from the High Court for an affidavit filed on his behalf which said the police had not taken Rajan into custody. **Police stance** Lakshmana, former IG, and Pulikkodan Narayanan, a former sub-inspector of the Panoor police station, the surviving two



P. Rajan

of the seven police officers who were involved in the detention and interrogation of those arrested, told The Hindu they had no knowledge about the arrest of Rajan, his death, and the disappearance of his body. Mr. Lakshmana blamed the Crime Branch, which

was probing the case, for all the trouble. "The reasons for Rajan's death are still unknown. I don't know anything about his reported detention or death. Though I was the Superintendent of Police in Kozhikode then, I never had any role in the proceedings as the investigation was carried out by the Crime Branch, led by the police chief Jayaram Padikkal," said Mr. Lakshmana. "I was falsely implicated in the case for my closeness to Karunakaran. However, the Sessions Court Coimbatore and the Madras High Court acquitted me, which was ratified by the Supreme Court," he said. Mr. Narayanan maintained that no one died at the Kakkayam camp dur-

ing the period. "I didn't see Rajan being brought there. The interrogation was carried out by senior officials, including Mr. Lakshmana, Jayaram Padikkal, and Madhusoodanan. Lower-rung officers like me had no role in it. Those who had a role in custodial violence went scot-free," he added. Meanwhile, Chandini, Rajan's sister, grieves over the loss of her only brother. She still does not know when and how her brother passed away. "All that we know from court records is that he is not alive. He would have turned 72 this year," she sobbed. The case and the legal fight of Varier had inspired a national award winning movie, Piravi (Birth).

Oman Air restores services offering relief to hundreds of expats stuck in the Gulf

Abdul Latheef Naha
MALAPPURAM

Oman Air's ramped-up services to 10 Indian cities and key global destinations has brought relief to hundreds of Indian expatriates stranded in the Gulf Cooperation Council countries, especially the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Oman. With Gulf flight operations disrupted by the conflict between Iran and U.S.-Israel, Oman Air's expanded operations have restored vital air links and reassurance for anxious travellers. Oman Air sources said several India-bound flights previously suspended during Ramzan were reinstated, and additional staff

The airline's expanded services has restored vital air links in UAE, Saudi Arabia and Oman

were deployed to handle the surge. Oman has also simplified transit documentation for expatriates from other GCC countries. Hundreds of Indian expatriates from the UAE are travelling to Oman's capital Muscat by road. The 450-km journey from Dubai takes about six hours, including roughly one hour for border clearance. P.K. Anwar Naha, general secretary of the National Kerala Muslim Cultural Centre (KMCC), UAE, re-

turned from Dubai via Muscat on Tuesday. He said that several students visiting family in the UAE or renewing residency permits opted for the road route to reach home in time for their exams on Thursday (SSLC) and Friday (Plus Two). Oman offers free transit passes for GCC residents; others pay five rials (about ₹1,100). **Umrah travellers** Many Umrah travellers stranded in Makkah and Jeddah flew to Muscat to catch flights to India. "In my flight, about 30% of passengers were from Saudi Arabia, mostly returning from Umrah," Mr. Naha said.

INBRIEF



Indian bond yield climb near 3-week high on crude spike

Indian government bond yields climbed to an almost a three-week high in afternoon trade on Wednesday, tracking a sharp spike in global crude oil prices amid escalating tensions in the Middle East. The yield on the benchmark 10-year government security rose to 6.7112%, its highest level since February 20, say market participants. Traders said surge in crude prices, particularly Brent crude nearing \$85/barrel, triggered sell-off in domestic bonds, pushing yields higher. PTI

PhonePe eyes up to \$10.5 bn IPO valuation in India

Walmart-backed Indian fintech firm PhonePe, the country's most used payments platform, is aiming to list at a valuation of between \$9 billion and \$10.5 billion, two people with direct knowledge of the matter said. That suggests the IPO will raise about \$900 million to \$1.05 billion. But even at the top end, the deal would mark a cut from the \$12 billion valuation at which PhonePe last raised \$100 million in private markets in 2023. REUTERS

Aurobindo Pharma ARM unveils cancer drug copy

Aurobindo Pharma subsidiary Eugia Pharma Specialities introduced Pomalidomide Capsule in the U.S. market. The product, used to treat relapsed or refractory multiple myeloma and AIDS-related Kaposi sarcoma, will be produced at Eugia Unit-I. The product is generic equivalent of BMS Pharmaceuticals Corp's Pomalyst Capsules. In the U.S. for 12 months ended January, Pomalidomide capsules had an estimated market size of about \$3.3 billion as per IQVIA MAT data.

MRPL said to declare force majeure on Mar. gasoline exports

Reuters
NEW DELHI

Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals (MRPL) declared force majeure on all upcoming gasoline export cargoes amid the West Asia conflict that has disrupted crude flows from the Gulf, two traders said. The company had already awarded two to three cargoes via tenders for early March loading and is in discussion with buyers on settling those supplies, one of the traders said. MRPL has swap agreements with traders to receive crude cargoes in exchange for supplying refined fuel, the trader added. The State-run refiner, which runs a 3,00,000-barrel-per-day refinery in Karnataka, exports about 40% of refined fuel output. Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz between Iran and Oman, a conduit for about a fifth of oil consumed globally, virtually stopped after Iranian attacks on vessels in the wake of U.S. and Israeli strikes that interrupted energy trade flows. MRPL did not immediately respond to a Reuters email request for comment.

U.S.-Iran war impacts Indian rice shipments to West Asia destinations

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Export of rice, which is mainly basmati varieties, to west Asian countries is suspended following the U.S., Iran, Israel war. Satish Goel, president of the All India Rice Exporters Association, said of the nearly six million tonne of annual basmati rice exports, 70% to 75% go to the west Asian countries. Of this, about one million tonne goes to Iran. All exports to Iran and other west Asian countries have stopped completely. There are goods in the ships that are stranded and at the ports. At a meeting with the Central government officials on Tuesday, the Association sought review of demurrage costs. Largest buyers The Indian Rice Exporters Federation national president Prem Garg told The Hindu that Iran, Saudi Arabia, Iraq and the UAE are among the largest buyers of Indian basmati rice and the exports are usually high between October and March every year. The Federation has issued an advisory to its members to not undertake new cost, insurance and freight commitments for those ports, however, run the risk of being targeted by Houthis. Qatar has halted LNG production after its facilities came under attack amid the ongoing West Asia conflict, disrupting supplies to India. India, which depends on long-term LNG contracts with Qatar for 40% of its annual natural gas needs, has seen a temporary suspension of cargoes. CNG prices to double? While some industrial users can switch to alternative but costlier fuels, the CNG-retailing city gas sector warned of severe stress. City gas distribution operators said replacing contracted Qatari volumes with spot LNG priced at more than double the contracted rate could erode CNG's price advantage and result in a permanent shift of customers to EVs. (With PTI inputs)

War puts oil, gas imports under stress

Many unloaded Indian oil tankers and gas carriers are awaiting orders from oil companies to proceed to other ports for alternative sources

Kalyanaraman M.
CHENNAI

The escalating war in West Asia is putting India's oil and gas imports under stress with tankers and gas carriers bound for India stranded in Persian Gulf and Qatar shutting down its Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) production facility. Some 200 international-trading crude oil and product tankers are stranded in the Persian Gulf following a total stoppage of ship movement across the Strait of Hormuz, as per Lloyds List Intelligence. Their data shows while China's Sino-peco has the most ships stranded among all owners, Indian government-owned Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) too is a leading owner whose assets are stranded.

Stranded at sea SCI ships with cargo carrying capacity of almost eight lakh tonne are stranded. Sanmar Shipping has ships with 3 lakh tonne of cargo capacity there. At least 22 Indian flagged oil tankers and gas carriers with almost 400 Indian seafarers onboard are stranded in Persian Gulf, said Anil Devli, CEO of Indian National Shipowners' Association. More than 35 Indian flagged ships are in the region, he said. All of India's Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG)



War effect: SCI ships with cargo carrying capacity of almost eight lakh tonne are stranded. REUTERS

needs are imported from Qatar and Saudi Arabia and they have been stressed too. The Indian government has said that India is in a 'reasonably comfortable position' with 25 days of crude oil in reserves not including the emergency-earmarked Special Petroleum Reserve and two to three weeks of LNG reserves. The government has assured that it had already been looking at diversifying LPG supplies. Overall, the Indian flag has some 140 oil tankers and gas carriers. Many unloaded Indian oil tankers and gas carriers are awaiting orders from oil companies to proceed to other ports for alternative sources, said Mr. Devli. Saudi Arabia is seeking to pipe fuel supplies to its ports on the Red Sea such as Yanbu as alternative export points, says Mr. Devli, adding ships calling on

those ports, however, run the risk of being targeted by Houthis. Qatar has halted LNG production after its facilities came under attack amid the ongoing West Asia conflict, disrupting supplies to India. India, which depends on long-term LNG contracts with Qatar for 40% of its annual natural gas needs, has seen a temporary suspension of cargoes. CNG prices to double? While some industrial users can switch to alternative but costlier fuels, the CNG-retailing city gas sector warned of severe stress. City gas distribution operators said replacing contracted Qatari volumes with spot LNG priced at more than double the contracted rate could erode CNG's price advantage and result in a permanent shift of customers to EVs. (With PTI inputs)

Investors continue selling stocks as crude gets dearer

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Indian investors continued selling, triggering the benchmark indices to tumble for the second consecutive session as oil prices surged on closure of Strait of Hormuz. Benchmarks Nifty 50 and Sensex 30 closed at 24,480.50 and 79,116.19, down 1.6% and 1.4% respectively on Wednesday, responding to oil surge. Nifty 50, where the volume is the highest, opened at 24,388.80, down over 2% from the previous close, slid to the day's low of 24,305.40 and hit the day's high of 24,602.45 before reaching the close. Twenty of the 21 sectoral indices declined, some of them crashing by more than 3% in a session. Only IT index improved by a marginal 0.1%. The rupee, meanwhile, closed at ₹92.05 a dollar, a fresh low, after the sustained increase in oil prices. This is a 7.3% depreciation from ₹85.47 a dollar in March 2025. Currency analysts say that this volatility is expected to continue in case of a sustained tension in the region. "Indian rupee recorded its steepest two-session decline since May 2025, as soaring energy prices intensified fears of persistent inflation and a widening trade deficit," said Dilip Parmar, research analyst, at HDFC Securities.

IRDAI sets April 1 for insurers to use Ind As

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) proposed April 1 for insurers to adopt Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS). The date will be applicable to all categories of insurers, including life, general, health insurers and re-insurers, IRDAI said, placing an exposure draft and a consultation paper in the public domain for comments. The move is aimed at promoting more consistency, transparency and comparability in financial reporting across the insurance sector in alignment with globally-accepted norms while preserving regulatory prudence and safeguarding policyholder interests, IRDAI said. The framework has been developed after comprehensive engagement with insurers. The steps are intended to aid smooth transition to Ind AS-based financial reporting.

MARKETS

MARKET WATCH		
	WEDNESDAY	% CHANGE
Sensex	79,116	-1.40
U.S. Dollar	92.05	-----
Brent oil	81.04	-----

NIFTY 50		
	PRICE	CHANGE
Adani Enter	2076.50	-48.10
Adani Ports	1434.40	-35.90
Apollo Hosp.	7666.00	-125.50
Asian Paints	2285.20	-21.90
Axis Bank	1351.30	-21.00
Bajaj Auto	9652.50	-123.50
Bajaj Finserv	1889.30	-52.60
Bajaj Finance	945.10	-33.15
Bharat Elec.	446.85	-7.10
Bharti Airtel	1905.90	-32.70
Cipla	1313.20	-38.40
Coal India	435.15	-8.90
Dr Reddys Lab	1291.20	-3.20
Eicher Motors	7626.50	-199.50
Eternal Ltd.	240.73	-2.14
Grasim Ind.	2683.20	-94.10
HCL Tech	1364.00	-7.00
HDFC Bank	866.65	-10.75
HDFC Life	684.60	-22.70
Hindalco	921.80	-18.20
Hind Unilever	2261.30	-59.30
ICI Bank	1365.40	-8.60
IntGlobeAvl.	4393.90	-127.50
Infsys	1307.40	-18.50
ITC	311.95	-2.95
Jio Financial Service	241.30	-7.70
es Ltd.	1213.00	-54.30
Kotak Bank	403.35	-9.75
L&T	3882.60	-184.10
M&M	3264.30	-70.00
Maruti Suzuki	14158.00	-230.00
Max Healthcare	1053.70	-29.90
NestleIndia	1245.30	-34.40
NTPC	365.80	-11.75
ONGC	276.95	-5.25
PowerGrid Corp.	291.95	-4.85
Reliance Ind	1345.00	-13.00
SBI Life	1930.60	-101.60
State Bank	1174.50	-15.40
Shriram Finance	1750.50	-2.00
Ltd.	1010.00	-42.50
Sun Pharma	1750.50	-2.00
TataConsumerPro	1110.60	-14.60
duct	196.73	-14.28
Tata Steel	196.73	-14.28
TCS	2587.80	-25.70
Tech Mahindra	1351.20	-5.80
Titan	4204.40	-65.90
Tata Motors PV	351.20	-19.40
Trent Ltd.	3756.80	-91.70
UltraTech Cement	12107.00	-414.00
Wipro	195.55	-3.02

Bullion futures recoil

Silver and gold prices rebounded in futures trade, tracking firm demand in international markets as investors sought safe-haven assets amid escalating tensions in the Middle East. PTI

Morbi ceramic units face shutdown on propane supply issue

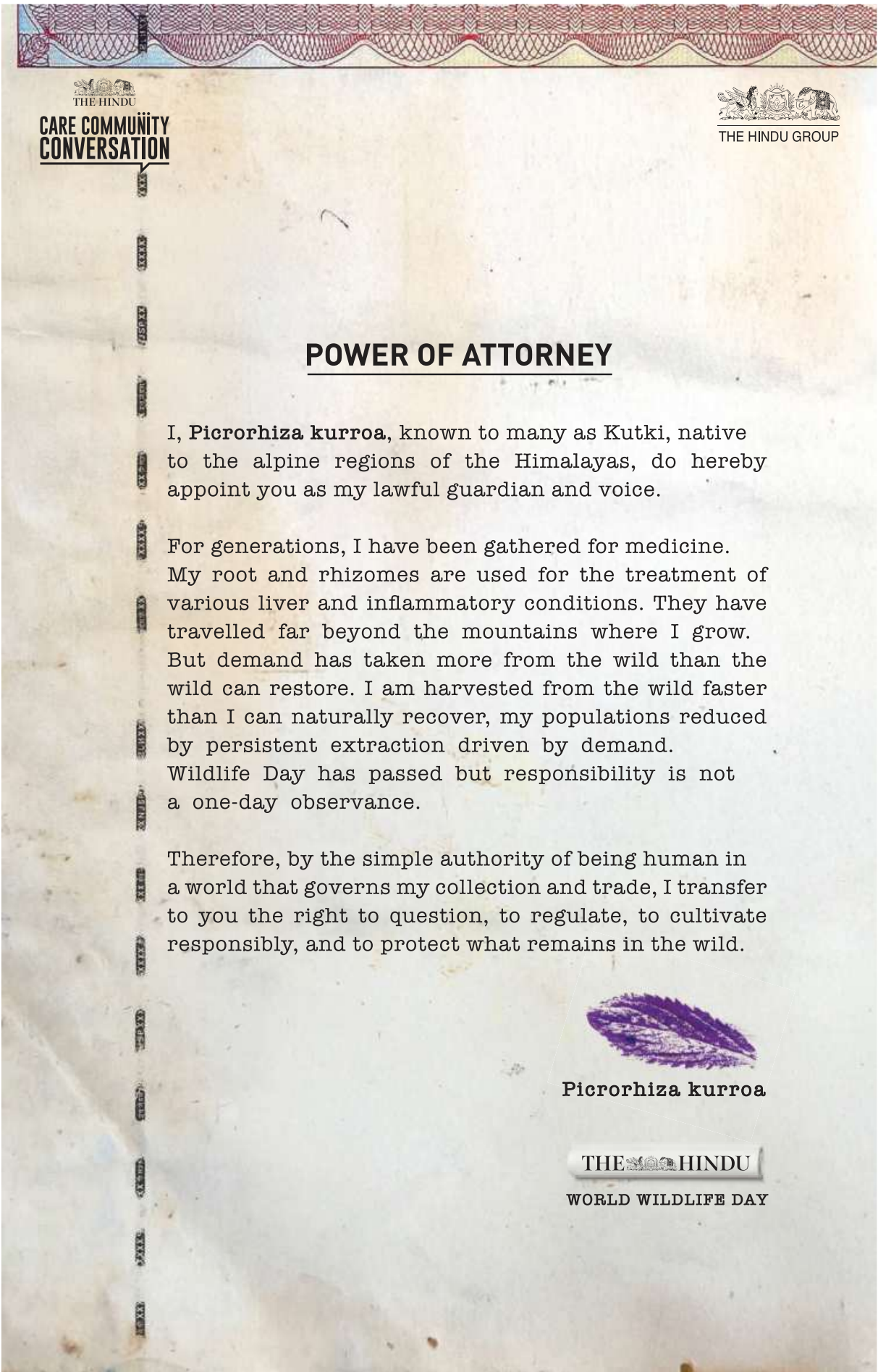
Avinash Nair
AHMEDABAD

Morbi in Gujarat, which accounts for 80-90% of India's ceramic production, is staring at an unprecedented fuel crisis triggered by the U.S.-Iran conflict. About 300 units running on propane are likely to start shutting down from Wednesday night or Thursday as propane supplies dry up and natural gas allocations are cut. "If the propane supply stops, then 70% of the units in Morbi are expected to shut operations. These units are expected to start



Almost 70% of Morbi ceramic units run on propane.

shutting down from Wednesday night or Thursday," said Manoj Arvadiya, president (vitrified tiles division), Morbi Ceramic Manufacturers Association. (The writer is with The Hindu businessline)



GENEVA
Children must be protected in West Asia war, say UN experts



REUTERS

The UN Committee on the Rights of the Child insisted on Wednesday that children must be protected during the war in the West Asia, highlighting an alleged air strike on an Iranian school. Iran has blamed Israel and the U.S. for the strike on the school in the Iranian city of Minab, giving a toll of more than 150 dead. AFP

WASHINGTON
Trump reclaims narrative, insists he struck Iran on his own terms



GETTY IMAGES

U.S. President Donald Trump and his team scrambled on Tuesday to reclaim the narrative on why he decided to attack Iran, after a top diplomat said that the U.S. struck after learning of an imminent Israeli strike. However, officials said that Mr. Trump authorised the strikes because Tehran was not “serious about a deal”. AFP

TEHRAN
Iran says it is ‘trying’ to swiftly appoint new Supreme Leader



REUTERS

Iran said on Wednesday it was trying to swiftly appoint a new Supreme Leader after Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was killed in U.S.-Israeli strikes on the weekend. “We are all trying,” said Ahmad Khatami, a member of the Assembly of Experts for Leadership which is responsible for selecting a new leader. AFP

BRUSSELS
EU says ‘ready’ to defend interests after Trump’s threat against Spain



REUTERS

The European Commission said on Wednesday it was “ready” to defend EU interests after U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to sever trade with Spain for refusing to allow U.S. use of its bases to attack Iran. “We stand ready to act if necessary to safeguard EU interests,” said commission spokesperson Olof Gill. AFP

U.S. and Israel continue hammering Iran

Tehran’s centre, Qom, other Iranian cities, and missile sites hit on fifth day of conflict; Israel says it downed an Iranian YAK-130 fighter over Tehran with an F-35; its military orders Lebanon border evacuations; Iranian authorities postpone mourning ceremony for Khamenei citing intense strikes

Associated Press
Agence France-Presse
DUBAI

The United States and Israel hit Iran’s capital and other cities in multiple air strikes on Wednesday, the fifth day of the war with Iran. Israel targeted the Iranian leadership and security forces as the Islamic Republic responded with missile barrages and drone attacks on Israel and across the region. Tehran residents woke to dawn blasts, and Iranian state television showed the ruins of building in the centre of the capital. The Shia seminary city of Qom and multiple other cities were also targeted. The Israeli military said one of its F-35 stealth fight-

er jets shot down a piloted Iranian Air Force YAK-130 fighter over Tehran on Wednesday. It also said Israeli air defences were activated to intercept Iranian missiles fired at targets around the country, and explosions were heard around Jerusalem. The tempo of the strikes on Iran was so intense that authorities postponed the mourning ceremony for Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed in the conflict, according to Iranian state television. Meanwhile, Turkey’s Defence Ministry said NATO defences intercepted a ballistic missile launched from Iran before it entered Turkey’s airspace. Iran has also attacked regional infrastructure.



Critical hit: Rescue workers carry the body of a victim after a strike on a building in Tehran’s Enghelab Square. AFP

Saudi Arabia said on Wednesday its Ras Tanura oil refinery, one of the world’s largest, was again targeted after an unsuccessful drone attack on it earlier in the week. The kingdom’s Oil Ministry said the latest attack did not cause any damage and supplies were not affected. Air sirens sounded in the morning across the island kingdom of Bahrain, home to the U.S. Navy’s 5th Fleet, and Qatar’s Ministry of Defence said Iran launched two ballistic missiles against it. One hit Al-Udeid Qatari Base but

didn’t cause casualties. The UAE’s Ministry of Defence separately said its air defences “successfully engaged with 3 ballistic missiles on Wednesday and detected 129 drones, of which 121 drones were intercepted while 8 fell on state territory”. The American Embassy in Saudi Arabia and the U.S. Consulate in the United Arab Emirates came under drone attacks on Tuesday, and the U.S. State Department said on Wednesday it had authorised non-emergency government personnel to evacuate the kingdom. Five days into a war that U.S. President Donald Trump suggested could last a month or longer, nearly 800 people have been killed in Iran, including some Mr. Trump said he had considered as possible future leaders of the country. Israel’s military, on Wednesday, ordered residents of dozens of border villages in southern Lebanon to evacuate “immediately,” adding that residents living south of Litani river should immediately head north. The military said it was “compelled to take military action” against Hezbollah, while the group claimed to have launched swarms of attack drones at an Israeli military base near Tel Aviv and a naval base in Haifa. The announcements came shortly after Israel activated air raid sirens following what it described as launches from both Iran and Lebanon.

IRGC claims it has ‘complete control’ of Strait of Hormuz

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran’s Revolutionary Guards said on Wednesday they had total control of the Strait of Hormuz, a key waterway for global energy transit, as Israel launched a new wave of strikes on the Iranian capital. Governments scrambled to evacuate citizens stranded by the war in the West Asia, with Iran expanding a missile and drone barrage on countries around the region on the fifth day of a war that sent global shares sinking. With energy prices already spiking, U.S. President Donald Trump had said the U.S. Navy was ready to escort oil tankers through the crucial Gulf shipping route.



An aerial view of the Strait of Hormuz. REUTERS

Earlier in the war, the IRGC warned ships against entering the strait, and major shipping firms have already suspended transit through the waterway with maritime agencies reporting several ships attacked. The Omani navy rescued 24 crew members of a Malta-flagged container ship struck by missiles while transiting the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday.

Moscow blames Kyiv for gas tanker attack in the Mediterranean

Agence France-Presse
TRIPOLI

Russia accused Ukraine on Wednesday of using naval drones to attack one of its liquefied natural gas carriers in the Mediterranean Sea off the Libyan coast, a strike which led to its sinking. Kyiv has not commented on the attack, which would be a rare successful hit on a Russian “shadow fleet” vessel while it was some 2,000 km from Ukraine. The Libyan port authority said the Russian carrier, Arctic Metagaz, sank after

Libyan port authority says the Russian carrier sank after ‘sudden explosions’

“sudden explosions” north of the port of Sirte. The ship “had experienced sudden explosions followed by a massive fire, which ultimately led to its complete sinking” on Tuesday night, it said. Moscow said the tanker had been attacked by Ukrainian naval drones in “an act of international terrorism and maritime piracy”.

Nepal to vote in first post-protest parliamentary election

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

Nepal is voting on Thursday in its first election since last September’s Gen Z protests that toppled the K.P. Sharma Oli government and led to the dissolution of the House of Representatives. The sudden eruption of the movement – marked by the unprecedented participation of thousands of young people – and the killing of 19 youth in police firing left the country in shock. The international community, too, was caught off guard. In total, 77 people lost their lives during the two days of protests, making it one of the most violent episodes in Nepal’s recent political

history. After Mr. Oli of the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) resigned, an interim government was installed – a move some say breached constitutional boundaries. The March 5 election, hence, is expected to restore constitutional order and bring the democratic process back on track. With a clear majority for any single party highly unlikely, analysts predict a return to a hung parliament and coalition politics – hallmarks of Nepali democracy in recent years. “A fractured Parliament, probably the most likely scenario, means that coalition negotiations will play a key role in shaping what comes next,” said Sanjay Upadhyaya, a U.S.-based Ne-



Polling officials make final arrangements at a polling station ahead of Nepal’s elections, in Kathmandu on Wednesday. PTI

pali author. “The journey ahead is twofold. Not only do parties need to find common ground, but they also have to manage differences within their ranks.” Nepal’s economic dependence on India remains substantial, with more than two-thirds of its

trade conducted with its southern neighbour. The two countries share an approximately 1,800-km-long porous border, which citizens of either country can cross without a visa or passport. New Delhi is not merely a development partner; it has historically exercised considerable influence in Nepal’s political processes. Though Delhi has appeared relatively hands-off since the Gen Z protests, it consistently pushed for elections on the announced date and extended logistical support. India’s stated position has been to “work with the government of the day in Kathmandu”. Yet it has not gone unnoticed that Mr. Oli’s ultranationalist rhetoric and his perceived tilt towards China had, at times, strained ties with Delhi. Analysts suggest India may quietly prefer a non-Left dispensation in Kathmandu. Such a government could be led either by the Nepali Congress, or by the Rastriya

Swatantra Party (RSP), a relatively new political force experiencing a groundswell this election. In November, the outgoing Chinese ambassador Chen Song reaffirmed China’s commitment to supporting Nepal for the successful completion of the March 5 vote. China has steadily expanded its footprint in Nepal in recent years. Its engagement became more assertive after Nepal’s communist forces united in 2018 under Mr. Oli to form a powerful Left alliance – a bloc that later imploded in 2021. The United States has also expressed confidence in a peaceful electoral process and indicated its readiness to work with the next government.

‘Unilateral moves generate strong resistance, damage U.S. credibility’

Wang Dong, a leading Chinese expert on global governance, shares a perspective on how the war on Iran by the United States and Israel, and the ongoing regional crisis is being seen in Beijing

INTERVIEW
Wang Dong

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

In an interview with *The Hindu*, Wang Dong, professor at the School of International Studies at Peking University and executive director of the Institute for Global Cooperation and Understanding, who is a leading Chinese expert on global governance and China-U.S. relations, shares a perspective on how the attack on Iran by the U.S. and Israel, and the ongoing crisis engulfing West Asia, is being seen in Beijing.

How do you view the strikes by the U.S. and

Israel and the latest developments in Iran? Are you surprised?

The latest military strikes against Iran have triggered a dangerous escalation in the Middle East [West Asia], pushing the region to the brink of a full-scale conflict. As an observer, I am deeply alarmed, rather than surprised. For years, tensions have been building over regional security, nuclear non-proliferation, and external intervention. What has happened is a reckless breakdown of restraint, violating the sovereignty of a UN member state and disregarding basic norms of international relations. Such moves will not resolve disputes.

China’s initial official statement on February

28 said it was “highly concerned over the military strikes” and called “for an immediate stop of the military actions”. But it did not condemn the strikes, which struck me as a rather measured response.

First, I need to correct this factual inaccuracy: China has explicitly and clearly condemned these military strikes. China’s position is consistent and firm. It opposes and condemns the use of force against sovereign states, stresses respect for sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity, and calls for an immediate end to military actions. This is not “measured restraint” but a principled stand anchored in the UN Charter and inter-



national law.

Have the developments in Venezuela and now Iran changed your view of, firstly, U.S. foreign policy under Trump, and secondly, how we might look at U.S. power in the world today?

Recent interventions in Venezuela and Iran reveal a

consistent pattern: a reliance on unilateral coercion, regime-change attempts, and military means as tools of foreign policy. This approach reflects a belief in military primacy and a disregard for international law and sovereign equality. As for U.S. power, these actions show that the U.S. still possesses strong military and coercive capabilities, but they also expose the limits of military supremacy. Unilateral moves generate strong resistance, damage U.S. credibility, and alienate partners. Hard power alone cannot sustain legitimate leadership; it breeds resentment and counter-balancing. U.S. influence is increasingly contested, and its ability to impose outcomes unilaterally is declining. Have the past few months changed your view of the world order as it stands today? Do these events speak to a world that’s still very much unipolar, or on the other hand, do these developments in some sense reflect a transition away from a unipolar, U.S.-led world?

The past months have reinforced my judgment: we are in an era of transition from unipolarity to multipolarity, not a still unipolar world. The U.S. still tries to act unilaterally, but it faces stronger pushback from sovereign states, regional groups and global public opinion. More countries refuse to choose sides or accept hegemonic dictates. The very fact that many nations, including major powers, condemn or oppose military strikes shows that the old unipolar system no longer works. These crises are not proof of lasting unipolar dominance; they are the last spasms of a fading order. The trend toward greater pluralism, multipolarity and rule of law is irreversible. Going back to the U.S. war in Iraq, what impact do you think it had on both China-U.S. relations and China’s rise in the decades since? Do you see any parallels today?

The Iraq War was a turning point. It drained U.S. resources, eroded its moral authority, and diverted its strategic focus, creating a relatively permissive external environment for China’s development. It also deepened global scepticism about unilateral military intervention. The lesson from Iraq is clear. Military ventures do not bring victory or stability. They bring chaos and long-term decline. That lesson must not be ignored. (Full interview at: newsth.live/WangDong)

Tamil Nadu

How Tamil Nadu got 234 Assembly seats: the Delimitation Commission’s calculated departure

Under Article 170 of the Constitution and Section 8(b) of the Delimitation Commission Act, 1962, the number of seats in a State Assembly must be an integral multiple of the number of Lok Sabha seats allotted to that State; a revised formula by the Delimitation Commission helped maintain effective representation and legislative balance in T.N.

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

Have you ever wondered how and when the Tamil Nadu Assembly’s strength was fixed at 234 seats? This number was arrived at by the Delimitation Commission, which undertook the post-1961 Census redistribution of Lok Sabha and Assembly seats.

Under Article 170 of the Constitution and Section 8(b) of the Delimitation Commission Act, 1962, the number of seats in a State Assembly must be an integral multiple of the number of Lok Sabha seats allotted to that State.

At the time, 14 States together accounted for 481 parliamentary seats. Madras (as Tamil Nadu was known then) had 41. In addition, Jammu and Kashmir had six seats, the Naga Hills-Tuensang Area one seat, the North East Frontier Tract one seat and the Union Territories 18 seats, taking the overall total to 507.

The Delimitation Commission – chaired by Justice J.L. Kapur, with C.P. Sinha and K.V.K. Sundaram as members – noted that Article 81(1) fixed the maximum number of directly elected Lok Sabha members at 500. This meant the maximum seats available for allocation among the 14 States was 493.

Uneven population growth

“The total population of these States has increased very considerably during the last ten years with the result that the average population per parliamentary constituency has increased from 732,654 in 1951 to 889,257 in 1961. Further, the increase is far from being uniform for all the States,” the Commission recorded.

After reviewing demographic changes revealed by the 1961 Census, the Commission concluded retaining the existing 481 seats would disproportionately penalise some larger States. Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Madras would each have lost three seats, while Bihar



Unique case: After the 1961 Census, Madras was the only State which saw an increase in the number of Legislative Assembly seats. The Delimitation Commission’s order said that the decision was not arbitrary. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

would have lost one. To mitigate this, the Commission increased the total from 481 to 490. Even then, Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Madras lost two seats each, while Bihar avoided a loss. The Commission recorded that even raising the number to the constitutional ceiling of 493 would not have altered the losses faced by those States. Accordingly, by Order No. 1, Madras’ Lok

Sabha strength was reduced from 41 to 39. The next step was to determine the size of the Madras Legislative Assembly.

At that time, the State followed a multiple of five – meaning each Lok Sabha constituency corresponded to five Assembly segments. Applying that formula mechanically would have resulted in: 39 × 5 = 195 Assembly seats.

However, the Madras Assembly then had 206 elected members. Retaining the existing multiple would therefore have reduced the Assembly to 195 seats, a significant contraction in representation.

The Commission examined whether multiples required revision across States. It noted while multiples broadly tended to rise as population declined, the pattern was not uniformly followed. After due consideration, it decided to retain the existing multiple in all States, except Madras.

A structural adjustment

Explaining its reasoning in its August 24, 1963 order, the Commission stated: “The Legislative Assembly of this State has at present 206 elective seats. Considering that its quota in the House of the People will for the future be reduced by two we think it proper to raise its multiple from 5 to 6 and to assign 234 seats to its Legislative Assembly.”

The revised formula thus became: 39 × 6 = 234. Instead of shrinking, the Assembly expanded. This helped maintain effective representation and legislative balance.

Other States saw no such alteration at the time. West Bengal retained its multiple of seven, resulting in 280 Assembly seats. Kerala, which then had 19 Lok Sabha seats, retained its multiple of seven, resulting in 133 seats. Assam retained nine, resulting in 126 seats. Uttar Pradesh continued with a multiple of five, producing 425 seats.

The decision was not arbitrary. It was a structural adjustment designed to preserve proportionality between parliamentary and Assembly representation while preventing a drastic contraction of the State legislature. Six decades later, the 234-seat structure remains unchanged.

The majority mark of 118, alliance arithmetic, constituency size and electoral strategy in Tamil Nadu continue to operate within the framework created by that 1963 decision.

Tamil Nadu’s saga of controversial Governors began with Sri Prakasa’s tenure in the 1950s

After the Congress failed to secure a majority in the 1952 Assembly election, Governor Sri Prakasa, a devout Congressman, nominated C. Rajagopalachari, who had retired from active politics, to the Legislative Council to become the Chief Minister; he did not take cognisance of former Congress leader T. Prakasam’s claim to form the government

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The role and actions of Governors have once again become a subject of political discourse in the country, especially in the context of their conduct in non-BJP, Opposition-ruled States. Recently, a High-Level Committee on Union-State Relations, constituted by the Tamil Nadu Government and chaired by Justice (retired) Kurian Joseph, recommended ways to ensure Governors do not remain tools of the Union Government’s overreach in areas of governance.

The panel’s recommendations come against the backdrop of the ruling DMK’s troubled relationship with Governor R. N. Ravi. However, the State is no stranger to controversial decisions of Governors since 1952. What the then Governor, Sri Prakasa, a devout Congressman, did then was more stunning than the election results, leading to a hung Legislative Assembly.

Return of Rajaji

He nominated C. Rajagopalachari (C.R. or Rajaji), who had retired from active politics, to the Legislative Council under the Constitutional provision allowing the nomination of individuals with special knowledge or practical experience in fields such as literature, science, art, the cooperative movement and social service. Three others – Mohamed Usman, V. Bhashyam Iyengar, and Omandur P. Ramaswami Reddiar – were also nominated.

In fact, it took weeks and considerable effort on the part of the Congress to persuade Rajaji—the only Indian to have served as Governor-General of India – to accept the Chief Minister’s post. But, when the talk of Rajaji becoming the Chief Minister again began doing rounds, his associate and prominent Tamil journalist-writer ‘Kalki’ R. Krishnamurthy, writing in his weekly, likened it to Ramana Maharishi becoming chairman of the Tiruvannamalai municipality, according to Rajmohan Gandhi’s biography *Rajaji: A Life*.

Expectedly, the nomination of Rajaji alone had raised a political storm because he had subsequently been appointed Chief Minister of the State, which had then encompassed parts of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Kerala. No one would, even then and now, question Rajaji’s literary expertise or his scholarship of literature and his nomination per se, but the issue that continues to be debated is whether a Council of Ministers, who are in office during the period of transition after an adverse popular verdict, can recommend to the Governor for filling vacancies in the legislative House, and whether the latter can act in favour of such a recommendation.



Controversial move: Jawaharlal Nehru, through a letter of April 3, 1952 conveyed his disapproval of his friend and Governor Sri Prakasa’s action.

Veteran Marxist leader P. Ramamurti of the Communist Party of India (CPI) challenged the Governor’s decision in the Madras High Court, and argued fiercely against the move, calling it a “malafide exercise” and a “fraud” on the powers of the office. However, the court dismissed his petition.

Nehru’s letter

In fact, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, during his retreat in Mashobra, Himachal Pradesh, conveyed, through a letter of April 3, 1952 his disapproval of his friend-Governor Sri Prakasa’s action, according to https://nehruarchive.in/documents/to-sri-prakasa-3-april-1952-z5epo. “I confess I am not too happy at these developments, more specially your having to nominate Rajaji to the Upper House,” Nehru wrote to the Governor, in response to his letter of March 31 and telegram on the political developments in the State. However, four days later, the Prime Minister expressed his

willingness to help C.R. and also explained his approach towards the leadership issue in Tamil Nadu. “Events moved fast in Madras, and I felt rather helpless here. I realized [sic] that any interference on our part from here would not help at all, and the matter must be decided in Madras itself by you and others. Naturally, I was reluctant to press you to accept this burden at this stage. On the other hand, all our efforts to find some way out also did not succeed,” Nehru stated in his letter to Rajaji.

1952 poll verdict

In the first Assembly election post-Independence, the Congress, which had secured an overwhelming majority in 1946, could not obtain a majority of its own. In the House of 375 members, the party could bag only 152 seats, emerging as the single largest party. The Tamil-speaking areas accounted for 96 in the overall tally of the Congress. What was significant about the verdict was that Chief Minister P.S.

Kumaraswami Raja and most of his Cabinet colleagues tasted defeat. The 1952 election was a forerunner to what the State and the Congress had experienced 15 years later, as the problem of rice shortage played a big role in tilting the scales against the incumbent regime.

C. Subramaniam, who became the Finance and Food Minister in the Ministry headed by Rajagopalachari, in his memoirs *Hand of Destiny* (Volume I), said the Congress had to pay “a very high price” in the election for pursuing the policy of rationing in the supply of rice. A perusal of reports of *The Hindu* published during January-March 1952 reveals the popular verdict was interpreted, in certain quarters, as the rejection of the Congress.

In the first general election held during January-February in 1952, the CPI, which finished second, secured 62 seats; the Kisan Mazdoor Praja Party (KMPP) 35, the Tamil Nadu Toilers’ Party (TNTP) 19, the Krishikar Lok Party (KLP) 15, the Socialist Party 13, the Commonweal Party six; the Madras State Muslim League five, the Forward Bloc (Marxists) Party three, the Scheduled Castes Federation (SCF) two and the Justice Party one, besides 62 Independents.

Given such a fractured verdict, the Governor added fuel to the fire by inviting Rajaji, who became the leader of the Congress legislature party on March 31, 1952, to form the government, even though it was quite clear the party did not have a majority of its own.

The United Democratic Front

T. Prakasam, former Congress leader who headed the KMPP, had staked claim to form the government on the ground that he had the support of 166 MLAs-elect, including the Communists. Claiming the support of most or all members belonging to the TNTP, KLP, Forward Bloc and the Commonweal Party, apart from 37 Independents, Prakasam had formed a coalition called the United Democratic Front. However, the Governor did not take cognisance of the rebel Congress leader’s claim and proceeded to appoint Rajaji the Chief Minister. A surprise inclusion in the Rajaji Cabinet was the Commonweal Party’s leader M. A. Manickavelu Naicker. By the time the Assembly was constituted in the early May, the strength of the Congress rose to 165.

The practice that came into vogue subsequently is that no incumbent government, as soon as the model code of conduct for the Assembly election comes into force, takes any policy decision. If it is to take any such decision on account of exigency, it has to seek the Election Commission’s nod. That way, Tamil Nadu can claim the credit for having been responsible for the formulation of the practice.

History-chasing India, England on collision course at iconic Wankhede

There hasn't been one standout performer, but Suryakumar & Co. have been able to eke out contributions from different personnel at key moments; Brook's men have had a grand campaign after an early loss to West Indies and the shift back from slightly tricky tracks in Sri Lanka to a potentially excellent one for batting isn't the most demanding

R. Kaushik
MUMBAI

It's a stadium steeped in tradition, but it hasn't shied away from sprucing itself up without disassociating itself from the past. The Wankhede Stadium has changed character in the 51 years of its existence, but it hasn't lost any of its character. Almost immediately after entering the premises through the Vinoo Mankad Gate, one is greeted by a statue of the original don of Indian batting, Sunil Gavaskar, his bat raised, captured mid-stride, a tribute to how the great man brought up his 10,000th Test run, against Pakistan in Ahmedabad in March 1987, with a dab past short third-man off off-spinner Ijaz Fakhri.

The long walk from the gate to the press box takes one through a plethora of stalls in the process of being set up and which will be bustling with greater activity on match evening. To the right of the press box, just past the stand named after him, is a towering statue of Sachin Tendulkar essaying an aerial straight drive. Tendulkar was Gavaskar's successor in every sense of the term; to have the statues of two of the greatest batters of all time is credit to the authorities here, who have also honoured other stalwarts by naming gates and stands after them.

One of the newer additions to the sprawling premises is the MCA Sharad Pawar Cricket Museum, curated by Devendra Prabhudesai and named after the former union minister who served as the president of the Mumbai Cricket Association and the Board of Control for Cricket in India, as well as headed the International Cricket Council. The museum is a veritable celebration of the rich history of Mumbai cricket, of its contribution to Indian cricket, and of its pre-eminent position as the leader of the pack when it comes to the sport in the country. There is a spectacular collection of memorabilia dating back to more than 80 years. The stirring deeds while representing the country of the greats of the game, men and women, are documented as meticulously as domestic giants who have played significant parts in Bombay/Mumbai winning the Ranji Trophy a staggering 42 times.

It's impossible not to feel the tug of cricket anywhere around the Wankhede, which has a unique touch to it. It's here that India created history on 2 April 2011 by becoming the first home side to go all the way in the ODI World Cup; it's also here that their challenge fell flat in the semifinal of the 2016 T20 World Cup, when they were well beaten by eventually champions West Indies.

Familiar opponent

The Wankhede offers India the unique opportunity of becoming the first side to replicate its 50-over heroics by lifting the T20 World Cup. Thursday isn't a final *per se*, but it could so easily be the final before the final. Standing between them and a Sunday date in Ahmedabad are Harry Brook's England, India's semifinal opponents for the third straight edition.

The teams have split their two previous last-four clashes, both remarkably one-sided affairs. Then skipper Jos Buttler and Alex Hales consigned India to a crushing ten-wicket hammering in Adelaide in November 2022 with a massive unbroken 170-run alliance, while India paid them back in the same coin in Providence in June 2024 when Rohit Sharma masterminded a 68-run rout with a sparkling 57. So much has changed in the 21 months since India backed up that victory with a seven-run heist against South Africa in the final. Alongside Virat Kohli and Ravindra Jadeja, Rohit rode into the T20I sunset within hours of holding aloft the trophy in Bridgetown; India have a new captain in Suryakumar Yadav, a somewhat left-field choice given that Hardik Pandya was Rohit's deputy during the American adventure. They also boast several survivors from their victorious previous campaign, but there is a string of exciting newbies, among them Abhishek



EMMANUEL YOGINI

Sharma and Ishan Kishan, the tyros that occupy two of the top three positions in the batting order, and wrist-spinner Varun Chakaravathy, currently the No. 1 T20I bowler in the universe.

Kishan has had his moments in this tournament, most notably against Namibia and Pakistan in the league phase, but has gone off the boil somewhat from the time he was dismissed in the first over in Ahmedabad by South African captain Aiden Markram in India's first Super Eight encounter. Even three months back, Kishan wasn't a serious threat to figure in the World Cup 15 but a change in mindset which ushered Shubman Gill out of the running coupled with the little Jharkhandi's spectacular form in domestic cricket compelled a rethink that took him ahead of Sanju Samson in the wicketkeeper-batter pecking order. Like most others in the Indian set-up, Kishan knows the Wankhede like the back of his hand, having plied his wares for Mumbai Indians in the IPL for several years before moving to Sunrisers Hyderabad for IPL 2025. Familiarity with a venue where one has had success previously certainly helps, and that's what Abhishek too will be hoping, because it was here that, in January last year, he blasted the living daylight out of England.

In a magnificent display of ball-bashing, the left-hander pulverised the bowling with seven fours and 13 gigantic sixes on his way to a 54-ball 135. England were lifted by the second-over dismissal of Sanju Samson with only 21 on the board, but ended up leaking 247, thanks mainly to Abhishek's effervescence. Jofra Archer, who has had a good tournament, went for 55 in his four overs and Adil Rashid 41 in three. Abhishek could do with some inspiration. He has had a poor tournament by anyone's standards, and hasn't looked like the No. 1 T20I batter that the rankings attest he is. Having taken four innings to make his first World Cup runs, his only contribution of note was 55 against Zimbabwe in Chennai. Maybe a return to the scene where he played his most bruising international innings is just the tonic he needs.

India were forced to split their left-left opening combine of Abhishek and Kishan after three straight first-over dismissals to off-spin. Kishan's wicketkeeping-opening slot has gone to Samson, who mainly came into the mix because his right-handedness offered a marked point of difference, but he proved that there is more to him than just that with a match-turning unbeaten 97 against West Indies in the virtual quarterfinal in Kolkata in Sunday. Samson has flattered to deceive in the past but the general feeling that he could have turned the corner after the Eden epic is strong. One of Samson's biggest enemies hitherto was self-doubt,

which threatened to consume him. Now that he knows what he can do at the international level - and we say this with all respect, even though he has three T20I tons to go with an ODI century in his last appearance for the country, in December 2023 - he will perhaps divorce himself from the gremlins that have eaten away at him for so many years now and become the sustained destroyer that he has shown himself to be with Rajasthan Royals in the IPL. One of the keys to India making it to the semifinals without really approaching their best is numerous different players coming to the party. There hasn't been one standout performer, but India have been able to eke out contributions from different personnel at key moments, be it a half-century here, a two-wicket over there, or even two fours in four deliveries, like Shivam Dube conjured in the penultimate over of the tense chase against the Caribbeans. Maybe there is nothing like the



perfect game - though India did have the near-perfect batting display in Chennai against Zimbabwe when each of their six batters weighed in handsomely in an intimidating total of 256 for four. But if there is, India still haven't produced it. Maybe that's something to look forward to, because what this side is capable of when it hits top gear is little short of awe-inspiring.

Buttler's struggles

England have had a grand campaign after an early loss to West Indies. Their spin attack manned by Rashid, Liam Dawson and Will Jacks has relished the assistance pitches in Pallekele and Colombo offered them during the Super Eights, when they had the measure of New Zealand, Sri Lanka and Pakistan. The shift back from slightly tricky tracks to a potentially excellent one for batting isn't the most demanding - certainly not half as much as going in the other direction - and it is on this that England will bank for Buttler to get back among the runs.

An acknowledged destroyer of the best bowling attacks, Buttler has been well off pace in a tournament where he has made a mere 62 runs in seven innings, with a highest of 26. If England haven't so much as contemplated leaving him out, it is because of his proven class. India will be hoping the sleeping giant doesn't wake up on Thursday, because if Buttler gets going, he will be well nigh impossible to stop.

Like India, England have won the World Cup twice, under Paul Collingwood in the Caribbean in 2010 and when Buttler masterminded their campaign in

Australia a dozen years later. Brook has run a tight ship, maintaining his composure and showing none of the off-field indiscretions that marked the beginning of his captaincy career. England came into the World Cup under a cloud following their 1-4 hammering in the Ashes, which cast a shadow over the coaching career of Brendon McCullum. They have earned themselves plenty of breathing room and if they are able to put it past the hosts and move into the title round, it will mark a tremendous revival, no matter how the final pans out.

Having taken the scenic route to the semis, India are within two wins of rewriting history by becoming the first three-time champions of the shortest World Cup. They will have the luxury of an entire nation rooting for them, but unless they execute their skills to perfection, all that support and backing will have little impact. For that, it is imperative that they pull up their catching and fielding socks, which have been in tatters for a while.

Maybe, they will derive inspiration from the stunning Tendulkar statue that is impossible to miss, and from the rich history of a ground where the great man made his final international appearance in November 2013.

THE GIST

▼ The Wankhede offers India the unique opportunity of becoming the first side to replicate its 50-over heroics by lifting the T20 World Cup. Thursday isn't a final *per se*, but it could so easily be the final before the final

▼ One of the keys to India making it to the semifinals without really approaching their best is numerous different players coming to the party

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Venezuela's oil exports in February amid shifts in trade patterns

737,000 It fell to around 737,000 barrels per day in February, a 6.5 % decline from January, as shipments to the U.S. and Europe could not fully offset a sharp drop in exports to China. REUTERS

U.S. targets hit inside Iran since the start of strikes

2,000 The U.S. military said it has struck nearly 2,000 targets inside Iran since launching attacks alongside Israel, focusing on ballistic missiles and other military infrastructure. AFP

Flights cancelled in West Asia between Feb. 29 and March 2

12,903 According to aviation data analysis firm Cirium, 40% of planned departures were cancelled between Saturday and Monday following the eruption of conflict in West Asia. AFP

Jobs provided in Andhra Pradesh in 21 months

6.28 In lakh. CM N. Chandrababu Naidu said that 6.28 lakh people have been provided employment across the private and public sectors. The government aims to exceed its target of generating 20 lakh jobs, he added. PTI

Estimated weekly damage to the Israeli economy from war

2.93 in \$ billion. Damage to Israel's economy from the air war with Iran could reach more than nine billion shekels (\$2.93 billion) a week, the Finance Ministry said on Wednesday. REUTERS
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What sparked the DoD-Anthropic clash?

Why did the DoD label Anthropic a supply chain risk? Did protections against surveillance and autonomous weapons trigger the fallout? Why did Anthropic refuse unrestricted access? Why was OpenAI able to negotiate terms that Anthropic rejected?

EXPLAINER

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

The U.S. Department of Defence (styled as the Department of War under the second Donald Trump administration) has entered into a public spat with the AI firm Anthropic, which makes the Claude AI product. The DoD has threatened to designate Anthropic a “supply chain risk,” dissuading a wide variety of firms that work with the U.S. government from patronising Anthropic’s products. ChatGPT maker OpenAI subsequently entered into the picture, obtaining an agreement it said was not radically different from what Anthropic wanted.

What is Claude?

Claude is an AI chatbot that helps organisations and individual users create and modify code. Its Claude Code product has been received extraordinarily well due to its capabilities. Claude Code is among the few AI products that is run with extremely powerful large language models (LLMs) while also supporting on-device creation and editing of tools, once it has access to a range of software libraries to work with.

The product is very compelling to the defence establishment because it can iterate on high-tech weapons and defence systems. Recruitment of programmers for these systems tends to be slow, as any critical weapons system is protected by several layers of secrecy, necessitating security clearances that can be time-consuming.

Claude Code has been a compelling proposition for the DoD, as it likely allows



REUTERS

for iteration on programmes that drive its technology quickly. While it does not execute programming tasks perfectly all the time, it performs well enough that development timelines have been shrunk in organisations that have deployed it widely, especially among experienced software developers.

Why did Anthropic clash with the DoD?

Anthropic was onboarded to the DoD as a part of a \$200 million contract last June, which allowed the U.S. government to use Claude’s services from dedicated infrastructure hosted by Amazon Web Services.

The issues between the firm and the DoD started on January 9, when defence secretary Pete Hegseth published a memorandum entitled “Accelerating America’s Military AI Dominance,” in which he called for the elimination of “blockers to data sharing, Authorizations

to Operate (ATOs), test and evaluation and certification, contracting, hiring and talent management, and other policies that inhibit rapid experimentation and fielding”. Anthropic has a much-publicised “constitution” for Claude that discourages the model from supporting widespread surveillance and enabling fully autonomous weaponry. Dario Amodei, the firm’s co-founder, insisted on strong language in the agreement between the DoD and Anthropic to bake in protections against domestic surveillance of U.S. residents and enable fully autonomous weaponry.

The firm was given until last Friday to relent and let the DoD have completely unrestricted access to its models. It refused, saying in a blog post that it would help the DoD transition to a new provider.

The DoD then classified Anthropic as a supply chain risk, a designation usually applied to firms that have such dodgy practices that their products can provide

foreign adversaries a backdoor into critical systems. While this designation only disallows DoD suppliers and partners from using Claude on systems dedicated to DoD, there are concerns that executives may lean toward caution and completely remove ties with Claude.

What is OpenAI’s agreement?

OpenAI negotiated an agreement with the DoD that the former claims has the same protections against surveillance and fully autonomous weaponry that Anthropic sought. It is not fully clear why OpenAI was able to land this deal while Anthropic was cast out. “The Department of War may use the AI System for all lawful purposes, consistent with applicable law, operational requirements, and well-established safety and oversight protocols,” a portion of the agreement made public by OpenAI said.

“The AI System will not be used to independently direct autonomous weapons in any case where law, regulation, or Department policy requires human control, nor will it be used to assume other high-stakes decisions that require approval by a human decision maker under the same authorities.” Anthropic is reported to have sought greater clarity in the agreement’s legal language that would prohibit the use cases described above, even if they were legalised.

“We think our red lines are more enforceable here because deployment is limited to cloud-only (not at the edge), keeps our safety stack working in the way we think is best, and keeps cleared OpenAI personnel in the loop,” OpenAI said in a statement. “We don’t know why Anthropic could not reach this deal, and we hope that they and more labs will consider it.”

THE GIST

▼ The DoD classified Anthropic as a supply chain risk after the firm refused to grant completely unrestricted access to its models, despite Claude Code being seen as a way to shrink development timelines and enable faster iteration on technology programmes.

▼ While the designation formally bars DoD suppliers from using Claude on systems dedicated to the DoD, there are concerns executives may lean toward caution and completely remove ties with the firm.

What will Nepal’s landmark general election decide?

Why were the polls called two years ahead of schedule? Is a hung parliament inevitable?

Sanjeev Satgainya

The story so far:

Nepal will be voting in a landmark general election on Thursday, in what many see as a quest for political change. The polls follow last September’s youth-led movement against corruption, misgovernance, and a patronage-driven economy long associated with an ageing political class.

Why is this election different?

The election is being held two years ahead of schedule because of the two-day Gen Z protests during which 77 people lost their lives, including 19 who were killed in police firing on the first day of demonstrations on September 8.

The vote is viewed as a corrective measure – an opportunity to break Nepal’s cycle of revolving-door politics that has plagued the country for decades and to create conditions for implementing the demands of the youth movement. Those demands – accountability, clean governance and economic reform – resonate well beyond the youth protesters and across the broader population.

What will this election decide?
Voters will elect a new House of

Representatives. Nepal’s House of Representatives, or Pratinidhi Sabha, is the lower chamber of the federal parliament and has 275 members – 165 elected through the First-Past-The-Post (FPTP) system and 110 through Proportional Representation (PR).

Voters cast two ballots: one for an individual candidate under FPTP and another for a political party under PR.

Under FPTP, the candidate with the higher number of votes in each constituency wins. Under PR, seats are allocated to parties based on their nationwide vote share. Nepal’s Election Commission uses the Sainte-Laguë method to distribute PR seats.

A party that secures at least 138 seats – a simple majority – can form a government on its own. If no party reaches that threshold, the single largest party is invited to form a government, typically through coalition-building.

What are the key political forces?

For much of the post-1990 democratic era, two parties have dominated Nepali politics – the Nepali Congress (NC) and the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) (CPN-UML). K.P. Sharma Oli of the UML was the Prime Minister, backed by the Nepali Congress, when the September protests took place.

In 2008, these establishment forces were disrupted by the rise of the Maoists, who entered electoral politics after ending a decade-long insurgency. Riding anti-incumbency sentiment and public demand for change, they emerged as a major force.

Following the recent protests, Pushpa Kamal Dahal of the Maoist Centre brought together around a dozen smaller communist factions to form the Nepali Communist Party. The new formation adheres to Marxism-Leninism and what it calls Scientific Socialism. However, many voters view it as part of the entrenched political establishment it once challenged.

A major new player is the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP). Formed just six months before the 2022 elections, it has generated a groundswell reminiscent of the Maoists’ rise nearly two decades ago.

As in 2008, anti-incumbency sentiment and calls for systemic change are shaping the political mood. The difference now is that the Maoists themselves are widely seen as part of the old guard. The RSP positions itself as a centrist liberal alternative to traditional parties.

The Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) advocates restoring the monarchy and reinstating Nepal as a Hindu state. Nepal abolished its monarchy in 2008 and formally became a federal democratic

republic under the 2015 Constitution. The RPP’s electoral performance has historically remained modest, but it cannot be entirely dismissed.

Another new entrant is the Ujyalo Nepal Party, founded in December by technocrat Kulman Ghising, who is widely credited with ending Nepal’s prolonged electricity shortages. Ideologically, the party mirrors the Nepali Congress’s democratic socialism but presents itself as technocratic and governance-focused.

When will the results be known?

Vote counting in Nepal is slow because of the complex ballot design and the large number of parties and candidates. As many as 67 parties and 3,405 candidates are contesting this election. Votes are counted manually. While FPTP results start to trickle in as counting in individual constituencies is completed, PR ballots must be tallied nationwide before final allocation. As a result, it may take up to a month for the final results to be declared.

What are the possible outcomes?

Nepal’s mixed electoral system makes it difficult for any single party to secure a majority. Analysts expect a hung parliament and a return to the same old coalition cycle.

The RSP is experiencing a groundswell, but converting public enthusiasm into actual votes remains a challenge.

Because this election follows a youth-led movement, turnout among younger voters could prove decisive.

The RSP could also benefit from voter fatigue, as many may vote for it not necessarily in the hope of miraculous change, but with the intent of teaching the old parties a lesson.

(Sanjeev Satgainya is an independent journalist based in Kathmandu)

THE GIST

▼ The polls were called two years ahead of schedule after the youth-led movement against corruption, misgovernance and a patronage-driven economy.

▼ Analysts expect a hung parliament, as Nepal’s mixed FPTP and Proportional Representation system makes it difficult for any single party to secure the simple majority of 138 seats.

CM